



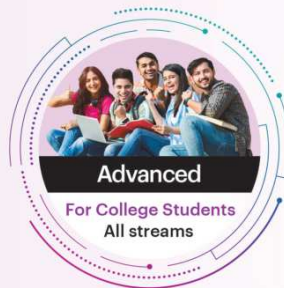
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Chief Guest

Thiru **B Rajkumar**

Minister for Housing and Urban Development,
Government of Tamil Nadu

Session 1 - 10:50 am to 11:20 am

Fireside Chat:

Building the Next Decade: The New Growth Blueprint for Real Estate

Mr Arun M N, Managing Director, Casagrand

Moderated by Mr L V Navaneeth, CEO, The Hindu Group

Session 2 - 11:25 am to 12:25 pm

The New Growth Triangle: Manufacturing, GCCs & Real Estate

Ms Kanchana Krishnan, Commercial Head, ANAROCK

Mr Julian Francis, Associate Director, RMZ

Mr Arun Prasad, Principal Architect, Arun & Associates, Coimbatore

Mr Sabareeswaran, Senior Vice President, Leasing & Business
Development, Casagrand Commercial

Moderated by Ms Soundariya Preetha, Deputy Chief of Bureau
(Coimbatore), The Hindu

Session 3 - 12:30 pm to 1:30 pm

Beyond the City Limits: Why Peripheral Chennai is Becoming the New Investment Destination

Mr Navin Kumar (Viswajith), Managing Director, Navin's

Mr Jerry Kingsley, Head of Research, India & City Lead for Capital Markets,
JLL Chennai

Mr Habib W S, Managing Director, RWD

Mr Gautam Agarwal, Chief Operating Officer, Casagrand

Moderated by Ms Sangeetha Kandavel, Senior Assistant Editor, The Hindu

Lunch - 1:30 pm to 2:30 pm

Session 4 - 2:35 pm to 2:55 pm

Student Presentation:

India's Vertical Forest Cities: Integrate Skyscrapers with Urban Farming, Biodiversity Corridors, Carbon Sequestration, and Cooling Landscapes

Ms Subhpradha P R, B.Arch, Final Year Student, Saveetha College of
Architecture & Design

Water-Positive Cities: Solving Urban Water Crisis Through Architecture

Mr Aldrich Bennet M, B.Arch, Final Year Student, Saveetha College of
Architecture & Design



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Session 5 - 3:00 pm to 4:00 pm

Building Economic Cities, Not Just Real Estate: The Future of Integrated Urban Development

Dr Jothilakshmy Nagammal, Principal, Saveetha College of Architecture & Design

Mr Arun Bharathi, Managing Director, GTB Urban Developers

Ms Pavithra, Co-Founder, Design Co Lab

Mr B L Ravi Kumar, General Manager - Network - 1, State Bank of India

Moderated by Mr Prince Frederick, Civic Affairs Editor, The Hindu

Session 6 - 4:05 pm to 4:35 pm

Fireside Chat:

Land as the Next Asset Class: Why Plotted Developments are Leading Tamil Nadu's Growth

Mr MV Manikandan, Founder & CMD, Adissia Developers

Moderated by Ms Soundariya Preetha,
Deputy Chief of Bureau (Coimbatore), The Hindu

Session 7 - 4:40 pm to 5:10 pm

Fireside Chat:

Why Tamil Nadu is Emerging as India's Next GCC Powerhouse

Mr Venkat Neelakantan, Senior Vice President - Head Asset &
Facilities Management, K Raheja Corporation, Mindspace REIT.

Moderated by Mr Jerry Kingsley, Head of Research, India & City Lead
for Capital Markets, JLL Chennai

Session 8 - 5:15 pm to 6:15 pm

Luxury Housing Boom: How Architecture is Redefining Premium Living

Mr Faisal Manzur, Founder and Principal Architect, Faisal Manzur Design Studio

Mr Kruthivas, Managing Director, Pushkar Properties Private Limited

Mr Deepak Jawahar, Architect & Co-Founder, The Architecture Story

Ms Sruti Reddy, Principal Architect & Creative Director, Ceebros Design Works

Moderated by Ms Sangeetha Kandavel, Senior Assistant Editor, The Hindu

Session 9 - 6:20 pm to 6:50 pm

Fireside Chat:

Beyond Bricks & Mortar: Why Risk Protection is Critical to Modern Infrastructure

Mr V N Sandeep, Deputy General Manager, United India Insurance

Moderated by Mr Kunal Shankar, Deputy Business Editor, The Hindu

Session 10 - 6:55 pm to 7:35 pm

Building the Future: How AI and Emerging Technologies are Transforming Construction

Mr Anson Sando, Co-Founder / Director - Elementech Circle, IIT Madras

Mr Ranjeeth Rathod, Managing Director, DRA Homes

Mr Santoshraj C S, Managing Partner, KeyStone Spaces

Moderated by Mr Kunal Shankar, Deputy Business Editor, The Hindu

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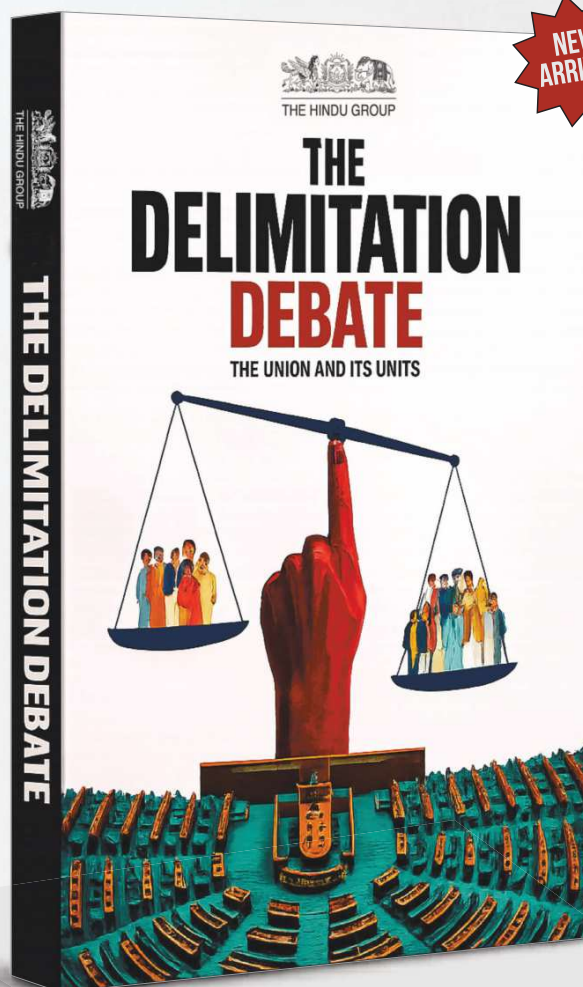
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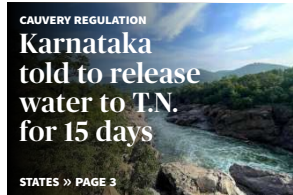
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MAJOR EARTHQUAKE
Many people feared trapped in Japan mall
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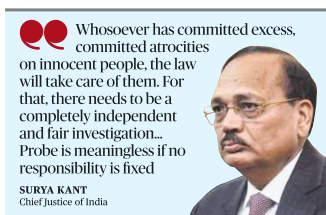
OPPORTUNITIES » PAGE 5

Release all minors held over student protests: SC

Top court mulls independent probe into allegations of police excesses during the protests; States permitted to proceed with probes, police restrained from taking 'coercive action' against students

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday indicated that it would consider constituting a high-powered investigation team to conduct a "thorough, fair, and independent" inquiry into allegations of police excesses during the recent student protests in Delhi and several States. While permitting the State authorities to proceed with the investigation of the FIRs registered in relation to the protests, the court ordered the immediate release of all minors arrested in connection with the demonstrations and restrained the police from taking coercive action against "protesting students" unless they had criminal antecedents.



The interim order permitting the authorities to proceed with the investigation of the existing FIRs raised concerns among the protesters on Tuesday, with the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), which led the demonstrations, contending that the direction was contrary to the Centre's assurance that no punitive action would be taken against protesters. Saurav Das, the CJP's spokesperson, said in a post on X that the order "raises extremely serious concerns" and is in "direct contradiction" to the Centre's assurance to the "youth of this nation". Underlining that the Constitution guarantees the right to peaceful protest, a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI)

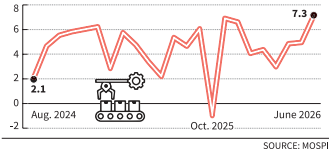
Surya Kant, while hearing a batch of petitions alleging disproportionate force by the police during the protests, observed that an independent probe was necessary to examine the allegations of police violence through a "scientific" and "evidence-based" inquiry. "Whosoever has committed excess, committed atrocities on innocent people, the law will take care of them. For that, there needs to be a completely independent and fair investigation... Probe is meaningless if no responsibility is fixed," CJI Kant said.

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Industrial growth hits 23-month high of 7.3%

Good tidings

Strong performance in manufacturing, electricity, and capital goods has fuelled the growth in June 2026, official data show



T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

India's industrial growth hit a near two-year peak of 7.3% in June 2026, fuelled by strong performance in manufacturing, electricity, and capital goods, official data released on Tuesday showed.

Analysts, however, caution that this strong performance might not continue in the face of a lower-than-expected monsoon and continued uncertainty due to the war in West Asia. The data on the Index of

Industrial Production (IIP), released by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, showed that the index's growth in June was the fastest since July 2024, a 23-month high.

The index had grown 5.1% in May 2026. Within the index, the manufacturing sector grew at a 23-month high of 7.8% in June 2026, compared with 5.5% in May, and 2.4% in June of last year.

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INBRIEF



L-G lays foundation stone for city's first dedicated dog shelter

Lieutenant-Governor (L-G) Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Tuesday laid the foundation stone for Delhi's first dedicated dog shelter in Dwarka, a year after the Supreme Court directed authorities to move aggressive and rabies-suspected stray dogs into such facilities. The Municipal Corporation of Delhi will build the facility in Sector-29, Dwarka, on 6,050 square metres of land. It is expected to be operational by the end of November, an official said.

Delhi Police attempted to arrest Aishe Ghosh, alleges SFI

The Students' Federation of India (SFI) on Tuesday alleged that the Delhi police attempted to arrest its national joint secretary Aishe Ghosh in connection with a 2021 protest case. "SFI national joint secretary Aishe, who was one of the leading student leaders of the recent wave of protests that resulted in the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan, is being subjected to witch-hunting by the Delhi police," the SFI stated in a release.

HC refuses to shift probe from officer seen 'slapping' woman

The Delhi High Court on Tuesday declined to transfer a 2025 probe into allegations of police excesses from the supervision of Additional DCP Sandeep Lamba, who was seen in a video allegedly slapping a woman during the July 20 protest, observing that an officer cannot be presumed to be biased in every matter due to allegations arising from another incident. "Just because he is caught on some video clip slapping a lady, we cannot tarnish him," Justice Girish Kathpalia said.

Stop witch-hunt of students or brace for new stir: CJP to govt.

Concerned that Centre, State govt. might 'weaponise' SC order: CJP, Delhi Police remains tight-lipped on withdrawal of FIRs filed during 36-day stir

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A day after warning of fresh protests over the Centre's alleged violation of the assurance that no punitive action would be taken against protesters, Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke on Tuesday called on the government to stop "targeting and witch-hunting" students.

"If the harassment of students at the hands of the police continues, the Cockroach Janta Party will respond with a massive peaceful protest soon," he posted on X.

The Bihar government said it had withdrawn FIRs against protesters registered before 6 p.m. on July 26, and the governments of Assam and West Bengal have followed suit. However, there has been no word from Delhi Police on the issue so far.

When reached for comment, the Delhi Police PRO declined to comment. Deputy Commissioner of Police (New Delhi) Sachin Sharma said, "We have not received any orders or official communication to withdraw the FIRs yet."

The police have not made any arrests related to the Delhi protest so far. A total of 14 FIRs were registered and 600 people were



Protesters celebrating at Jantar Mantar on July 25 after hearing about Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

detained and subsequently released in the South East district where the prohibitory orders were imposed. On July 25, the 36th day of the protest, the CJP called off its stir after the Centre agreed to its three main demands — ouster of Dharmendra Pradhan as the Union Education Minister, compensation for the families of those who ended their lives after the cancellation of NEET on May 31, and withdrawal of FIRs against the protesters and an assurance that no future action would be taken against them.

'Credible apprehension' The CJP also expressed concern over the Supreme Court's directions on Tuesday allowing State authorities to proceed with the investigation of the FIRs registered in connection with the protests.

"We now have a credi-

ble apprehension that the Government of India and BJP-ruled states may seek to use and weaponise this order of the Bench led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant to continue FIRs against individual protesters and subject them to great harassment. This was precisely our concern from day one: that courts could be used, directly or indirectly, to achieve political ends by targeting peaceful dissent," CJP's chief spokesperson Saurav Das stated in a post on X.

Later in the day, Mr. Das said the Centre had not yet fulfilled its promise to share by Tuesday night the written assurance of the agreement they reached three days ago.

"They met me in the evening and conveyed the court order, I shared my objections. There has been no response from them after that," he said.



Commuters wading through a waterlogged road in New Delhi on Tuesday; (below) a view of Jama Masjid. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP/PTI

Heavy rain leaves city waterlogged, triggers AAP-BJP war of words

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) locked horns over waterlogging after heavy rain lashed the national capital on Tuesday, leaving several parts of the city inundated.

AAP Delhi president Saurabh Bharadwaj said, "In Sadar Bazar, one of Delhi's largest wholesale markets, schoolchildren are being forced to pass through waist-deep rainwater. Thank you, CM Rekha Gupta. After Gen Z, now Gen Alpha, too, will remain indebted to the BJP."

Hitting back, Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra claimed that barring 2025, the city had witnessed waterlogging every monsoon for the past 27 years even after light rain.

He said the BJP government has "almost freed the city from the waterlogging problem."

Meanwhile, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, accompanied by senior officials, travelled on a Delhi Transport Corporation bus to assess



the ground situation and review key civic works.

The Chief Minister began the inspection from her camp office in Civil Lines and travelled by bus via the Outer Ring Road and Madhuban Chowk to the DDA Sports Complex in Sector 33, Rohini.

She also reviewed the progress of waste disposal operations at landfill sites along the route.

57.6 mm rainfall

The Safdarjung weather station recorded 57.6 mm of rainfall till 5.30 p.m., according to the weather department. Civic authorities responded to at least 136 complaints related to waterlogging, uprooted trees and power outages.

HC has no jurisdiction to stay eviction of Gymkhana Club: Centre

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Centre has opposed a plea before the Delhi High Court seeking a stay on eviction proceedings against the Delhi Gymkhana Club, contending that the court lacks jurisdiction to entertain the application.

In its reply to an interim plea by club member Vijay Khurana, the Centre on Monday said that Section 15 of the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act creates a "two-fold" bar by excluding civil courts from proceedings relating to eviction from public premises and prohibiting the grant of "any injunction in respect of any action taken or to be taken by the Estate Officer".

The dispute stems from the Centre's decision in May to terminate the Delhi Gymkhana Club's perpetual lease, stating that the land is required for defence infrastructure and other security purposes. Mr. Khurana and the club's Staff Welfare Association have challenged the move before the High Court.

The case came up before Justice Anvesh Jhingran on Tuesday. Senior advocate Abhishek Manu Singhvi, representing Mr. Khurana, submitted that the Centre's reply had been served late on Monday night, and sought time to file a rejoinder. The court granted the request and listed the matter for September 3.

Lakshmi Yojana to roll out on August 28; women with more than three children ineligible

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Women with more than three children will not be eligible for the Delhi government's ₹2,500 monthly assistance under the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana, according to the additional eligibility criteria announced by the government on Tuesday.

According to an official release from the Chief Minister's Office (CMO), the government aims to release the first instalment of the assistance to nearly 17 lakh eligible women on Raksha Bandhan, which falls on August 28.

It quoted Chief Minister Rekha Gupta as saying that an online portal for applications would be launched on August 1.

According to the CMO, women

already receiving benefits under any other financial assistance scheme or pension, taxpayers, government employees, those who file GST, women with more than three living children and families with annual electricity consumption exceeding 2,400 units will not be eligible for the scheme.

Ms. Gupta said eligible women would have two options to receive the monthly assistance.

Under the first, ₹1,500 would be deposited in a recurring deposit (RD) or fixed deposit (FD) account while ₹1,000 would be credited to a digital rupee wallet.

"Under the second option, beneficiaries may choose to receive the entire ₹2,500 in an RD/FD. This option is intended to help women build savings," she added.

GOVERNMENT OF JAMMU & KASHMIR OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER IRRIGATION DIVISION KULGAM (192231) Invitation for Bids (Notice Inviting Tenders) e-NIT No. 07 of 2026-27 Dated: 25-07-2026		
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S. No.	Title	Details
1.	Name of the Work	MODERNIZATION OF NANDI CANAL.
2.	Source of Funds / Scheme Code	NABARD LOAN Assistance (Irrigation Sector) I&FC Kashmir, MH-4702
3.	Estimated Cost	₹1835.35 Lacs
4.	Position of Administrative Approval	Accorded vide Govt. order No. 289-JK (JSD) of 2025 Dated: 16-12-2025, issued vide order No. KFCID-DBDIPRM/3/2025-6-CE I&FC KASHMIR (e-702934) Dated: 16-12-2025.
5.	Position of Technical Sanction	Accorded vide Chief Engineer Kmr. I&FC Department Srinagar's order No. 96-DB of 2025-26 dt. 30.01.2026 Issued vide endorsement No. CE/DB/TS/17128-29 Dated: 30.01.2026.
6.	Position of Funds	Assured
7.	Period of Completion	(03) Three years
8.	Cost of Tender Document	₹ 10,000/- Tender document fee is to be deposited from any Scheduled bank as per Govt. of J&K Finance Department (Codes Division) Circular No. F3-Code/290/2026 dated: 22/05/2026.
The designated Account number as communicated vide Chief Engineer Kmr. I&FC Department Srinagar's No. CE/I&FC/DB/6518-47 dated: 16/06/2026 is as under: Account Name: Chief Engineer Kashmir Irrigation & Flood Control Department Srinagar. Account No.: 03670102000000000000 IFSC Code: JAKA0TANKEE Bank: J&K Bank Ltd. Tunkpora Branch. (Payment receipt mentioning Transaction ID, Date and all details shall be uploaded online).		
9.	Website/portal address	https://jtenders.gov.in
10.	Earnest Money Deposit (in Lakhs)	₹ 36.70/- Lacs. The validity of the EMD should be 45 days beyond Bid Validity (120 - 45) days.
11.	Selection Criteria / Eligibility Criteria	As defined in SBD of this work.
12.	Period of Tender Validity	The Tender shall remain valid for 120 days after the bid submission end date.
13.	Critical Dates	
a)	Publishing date and time of tender Amendments documents	
b)	Starting date & time for downloading of tender documents	
c)	Pre-Bid meeting, site visit and clarification to tender documents.	
d)	Starting date and time of bid Submission (Cover No. 1 to 2)	
e)	Closing date and time of bid Submission (Cover No. 1 to 2)	
f)	Date and time of bid opening (Cover No. 1)	
g)	Date and time of bid opening (Cover No. 2)	
1. A pre bid meeting will be held to clarify issues and to answer questions on any matter that may be raised at that stage by the bidders.		
2. Prospective Bidders within UT of J&K shall submit/deposit the tender Document Fee (Non-Refundable/ Non-Transferable) as per any Scheduled bank as per Govt. of J&K Finance Department (Codes Division) Circular No. FD-Code/290/2026 dated: 22/05/2026. The designated Account number as communicated vide Chief Engineer Kmr. I&FC Department Srinagar's No. CE/I&FC/DB/6518-47 dated: 16/06/2026 is as under: Account Name: Chief Engineer Kashmir Irrigation & Flood Control Department Srinagar. Account No.: 03670102000000000000 IFSC Code: JAKA0TANKEE Bank: J&K Bank Ltd. Tunkpora Branch.		
3. Earnest Money / Bid Security will also be credited to the designated account mentioned in point No. 2. Same shall be valid for 120-45 days (i.e. Not less than 165 Days) beyond bid validity.		
4. Furnishing of hard copies of bids immediately after submission of e-tenders is dispensed with. The same shall be obtained only from the bidder who is declared as L1 tenderer opening of financial bids as per Finance Department C.M. No. A24/2017 dt. 15-12-17 dt. 07-09-2018.		
5. The Contractor shall have to arrange all the key construction material for successful completion of the work. No Departmental material shall be issued.		
6. Further details can be seen in bidding document available on website: www.jtenders.gov.in		
7. Conditional bids and the bids not meeting the qualifying criteria shall be summarily rejected.		
8. The authority reserves the right to cancel any or all bids without assigning any reason.		
9. Subsequent Contingendum/Addendum if any shall be published on above website.		
10. All other terms and conditions shall be same as laid down in the PWD Form-25 double & codal procedures shall be followed in accordance with GFR-2017 and the Procurement Manuals issued by the Ministry of Finance, Department of Expenditure, Government of India, as amended from time to time.		
No: 2596-2611 Dated: 7/25/2026		
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NATIONAL HINDI DEBATE



Delhi Public School, Rohini, hosted 'Vicharvithi 2026', the Inter-DPS Hindi Debate (National Level), under the aegis of the Delhi Public School Society. Students from 114 Delhi Public Schools participated, with 22 finalist teams reaching the Grand Finale. Principal Mrs. Kanika Sachdeva Gopi welcomed the gathering and highlighted the importance of language and identity. Mrs. Dolly Chanaana, Director, Delhi Public School Society and National Convenor, and Ms. Ambika Kaul graced the event. Mrs. Dolly Chanaana appreciated the school's efforts, and winners were honoured for their outstanding debating skills.

ALUMNI MEET HOSTED



Sachdeva Public School, Rohini, hosted an Alumni Meet, bringing together former students from the foundation years to the 2008 batch. Alumni reconnected with their classmates and teachers, revisited classrooms and shared their career journeys and memories. A highlight of the event was meeting the school's former Principal, whose guidance had inspired generations of students. Director Mr. Sanjay Sachdeva and Principal Dr. Namita Sharma said the alumni's achievements reflected the school's vision and encouraged them to remain connected, mentor future generations and contribute to the institution's continued growth.

SPELL BEE SUCCESS



Seth Anandram Jaipuria School, Kanpur, celebrated the achievements of their students in the Spell Bee International Competition 2025-26. At the International Stage, students displayed outstanding language proficiency, confidence and analytical skills. Mhd. Arafat Khan (Grade II, CISCE) and India Tasmeen Rahman (Grade II, CIE) secured the shared First National Rank in their respective categories. Zain Amir Mahmood (Class III), Advit Khaitan (Class V) and Tanish (Class VI) secured Fifth International Rank, while Raghav Gupta (Class IX) achieved Second International Rank. All rank holders will be felicitated with trophies and gift hampers.

For Subscription related queries, please contact Kapil Nagar:
Handphone: +91 9810089457 / Email: kapil.nagar@thehindu.co.in

**GOVERNMENT OF TAMIL NADU
TAMBARAM CITY MUNICIPAL CORPORATION**

ROC No. 272/2026/E1 NOTICE FOR NATIONAL INVITING TENDER Date: 27.07.2026

1. Tenders are invited from the eligible bidders for following work:
i. Providing Breakfast under Purnathalaivar Kamraj Breakfast Scheme to Students studying from Classes I to VIII in Government Schools and Government Aided Schools for a period of three years in TMC.

2. Value of the work is Rs. 1287.10 Lakhs

3. The details of the tender shall be downloaded from 03.08.2026 from the portal: https://tn.tenders.gov.in

4. The last date for downloading the tender document and the last date for uploading/ submission of filled up tender document is up to 3.00 pm on 03.09.2026.

5. The received tenders will be opened at 3.30pm on 03.09.2026 at Tambaram Corporation Main Office.

6. Pre-Bid Meeting will be held at 11.00 AM on 17.08.2026 at Tambaram Corporation Main Office.

7. The value of work, the details of earnest money deposit, and eligibility of bidders are given in the tender document.

Commissioner,
Tambaram City Municipal Corporation

DHPK/2380/Tender/2026

DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED

EMPLOYMENT NOTICE

Delhi Transco Limited, a wholly owned Company of Government of NCT of Delhi, invites applications for appointment on Deputation Basis to one post of General Manager (Finance) (Pay Level-15) (Rs. 1,88,200-2,24,100) alongwith usual allowances as admissible under the rules of the Company.

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35 postal bags set ablaze in Manipur

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Amid a highway blockade in Manipur, miscreants intercepted a mail van on National Highway 202 and set 35 postal bags containing passports, ATM cards, educational documents, and other articles. The incident occurred in the Ukhrul district on July 27.

Wungreipam Rimai, the postmaster at the Ukhrul Sub-Post Office, said the Department of Posts was transporting the consignments.

Timings

WEDNESDAY, JUL 29	
RISE 05:41 SET 19:14	
RISE 19:17 SET 07:07	
THURSDAY, JUL 30	
RISE 05:42 SET 19:14	
RISE 19:51 SET 06:05	
FRIDAY, JUL 31	
RISE 05:42 SET 19:13	
RISE 20:22 SET 07:02	

Delhi Weather	max	min
Delhi City	31	26
Safdarjung	31	26
Palam	31	24

Delhi Palam Today
31°C The weather will be slightly warm. Few spells of moderate rain and thundershower with gusty winds to occur.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow
32°C The weather will be little warm. Few spells of moderate rain and thundershower with gusty winds to occur. Night will be comfortable.

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THE HINDU

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Release Cauvery water to T.N., panel tells Karnataka

CWRC orders Karnataka to release 3,500 cusecs of water daily for 15 days from today; State likely to appeal against order; Minister says present storage can only meet drinking water needs

B.S. Satish Kumar
BENGALURU

The Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC), which met in Delhi on Tuesday to review the situation in the drought-hit Cauvery basin, has directed Karnataka to release 4 tmcft of water to Tamil Nadu at a rate of 3,500 cusecs a day for 15 days.

After examining the live storage in Karnataka and Tamil Nadu reservoirs and the anticipated worsening of El Nino conditions, the committee directed Karnataka to ensure a flow of 3,500 cusecs at the Biligundlu measuring gauge on the inter-State boundary, commencing from 8 a.m.



Interim relief: Tamil Nadu had received only 3,543 tmcft of water as against the prescribed 35,391 tmcft till July 26. K. MURALI KUMAR

on Wednesday. When contacted by *The Hindu*, Karnataka Water Resources Minister K. Ramalinga Reddy said the State would examine the possibility of filing an appeal against the order before the Cauvery

Water Management Authority (CWMA), which is the apex body that monitors implementation of Cauvery water release.

Mr. Reddy said he would hold a meeting with officials concerned in this re-

gard on Wednesday in Bengaluru and later consult Chief Minister D. K. Shivakumar to arrive at a decision. He maintained that the storage in the four reservoirs of Cauvery basin in Karnataka was sufficient to take care of only the drinking water requirements of the State.

Till July 26, Tamil Nadu had received only 3,543 tmcft of water as against the prescribed 35,391 tmcft, which accounted for only 10.01% of the stipulated quantum, the State said.

Tamil Nadu contended that it had not received its pro-rata share in accordance with the inflows into Karnataka's reservoirs and there was a backlog of 9.46 tmcft.

T.N. CM writes to PM seeking intervention in dam row

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Tuesday wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, seeking his intervention to ensure that no statutory or administrative approval is granted to the proposed Mekedatu project unless it is demonstrably consistent with the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal's award and the judgment of the Supreme Court.

Mr. Vijay also called for the withdrawal of the reply given by Union Minister of State for Jal Shakti Raj



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay. FILE PHOTO

Bhushan Choudhary in the Rajya Sabha on July 27 with regard to the project. The Minister had said the Supreme Court's judgment of February 16, 2018, did not stipulate that Karnataka should obtain the consent of the lower riparian States

before constructing a structure across the Cauvery. Mr. Vijay said the Minister had made the reply without referring to the settled law and legal principles in inter-State water issues.

He said the Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court had, in the Alamatti case between Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh, ruled that the consent of the lower riparian State was absolutely necessary. Mr. Vijay also quoted the relevant paragraph from the judgment, which said: "Nor can Karnataka State be permitted to construct up to that height without the consent

of all other riparian States as well as without the approval of the Central Government."

Tribunal's award

As for the Tribunal's award, the Supreme Court expressly affirmed Clause XVIII of the award, which preserves the power of each State to regulate water within its territory only "in a manner not inconsistent with the order of the Tribunal". Thus, any project with the potential to affect the regulated flow regime established under the award required scrutiny for consistency with the

Delhi HC asks EC to ease SIR duty burden on teachers

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Tuesday directed the Election Commission (EC) to ensure that schoolteachers deployed for the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in the city are not subjected to an "unbearable" burden.

A petition filed by advocates Rajesh Kumar Gogna and Ashok Agarwal contended that the mass deployment of schoolteachers for the SIR was adversely affecting the education of lakhs of students in Delhi.

A Bench reiterated that EC's powers must be exercised in compliance with the Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education (RTE) Act, 2009.



Campaign centred on Pinarayi cost LDF in Kerala poll: CPI(M)

G Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Central Committee of the Communist Party of India (Marxist)'s review of the Assembly election results pointed out that "personalising the electoral campaign and centering it solely around" former CM Pinarayi Vijayan were among the several factors that cost the Left Democratic Front (LDF) its "political initiative".

The review, published online on Monday, noted that individualising the campaign enfeebled the party's core Left-secular messaging against the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF)'s "reactionary ruling class" bias and rendered Mr. Vijayan the prime target of a vilification campaign.

The assessment noted that the CPI(M)'s disproportionate stress on the social capital generated by the previous LDF govern-

ment's development and welfare policies obfuscated the party's anti-corporate, anti-communal, and anti-neoliberal messaging to the masses.

Political vacuum

The consequent dearth of a distinctly Left-secular message created a political vacuum that the Congress, Indian Union Muslim League, and the Jamaat-e-Islami sought to fill by pushing the patently false narrative that the CPI(M) was in cahoots with the Hindu majoritarian forces backing the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). The distorted campaign "influenced and misled some sections of the Christian minority into joining the reactionary gang-up against the LDF".

The Central Committee noted that the CPI's stance on PM SHRI gave a leg-up to the UDF's campaign that an "undercurrent exists" between the CPI(M) and the BJP.

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States

IN BRIEF



Sharad Pawar puts an end to speculations on NCP merger

NCP (SP) leader Sharad Pawar on Tuesday put an end to speculations about the likely merger between the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) and Sunetra Pawar-led NCP group. "It has no relevance," he said, while speaking to reporters in Baramati. The statement assumes significance against the backdrop of reports of likely talks between the two factions. Over the last few months, several leaders had said that it was deceased NCP leader Ajit Pawar's last wish to see both the parties together.

No paper leak case in Punjab. Oppn. lying: Minister Cheema

Punjab Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema on Tuesday rejected the Opposition's charge of a paper leak in the State, claiming that it is trying to spread lies against the AAP government. Addressing the media here, Mr. Cheema said there has been no paper leak in the past four years of the Bhagwant Mann government. Opposition parties have been attacking the Mann government over the issue of a cheating racket detected recently in a pharmacy officer recruitment exam and are demanding the resignation of Education Minister Harjot Singh Bains and Health Minister Balbir Singh.

Police withdraw FIR filed suo motu against protesters in Kolkata

A city court grants bail to all 16 accused after initially remanding them in 2-day judicial custody; not applicable to persons with criminal past: govt.

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

Kolkata Police on Tuesday withdrew an FIR that it had filed suo motu against protesters for allegedly resorting to violence during a march on July 24 in the city's Esplanade area in support of students agitating at Jantar Mantar in Delhi demanding the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Union Education Minister.

After the police dropped the charges, the Chief Metropolitan Magistrate's court granted bail to all 16 accused on a bond of ₹500. The accused were arrested from different places in and around the city. The court initially sent them to judicial custody till July 30.

The West Bengal Home and Hill Affairs Department had issued the formal order withdrawing the case. It clarified that no coercive measures shall be taken against the students who participated in the protest. However, the department also said, "The above protection shall not



The accused arrested in connection with violence during a protest on July 24 being produced before a court in Kolkata on Tuesday. ANI

extend to persons having criminal antecedents, as mandated in the order of the Hon'ble Court...."

Seven FIRs were registered in connection with the violence, including the suo motu case lodged by the police and six others filed on the basis of complaints made by journalists who suffered injuries while covering the July 24 march.

Chief Minister Suvedu Adhikari had earlier claimed that the accused will be booked under the newly passed West Bengal Public Safety and Control

of Anti-Social Activities Act, 2026, commonly called the 'Goonda Act'.

'Breach of agreement' Kolkata Police's decision to withdraw the FIR came a day after the Cockroach Janta Party, which spearheaded the protest in Delhi against the alleged NEET paper leak, said the Centre should not breach the agreement to withdraw all police cases against protesters. Similar FIRs registered against protesters in Assam and Bihar were withdrawn on Monday.

'A lawyer in court dress, agents delivering food': people who landed in Assam Police's custody

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

On the afternoon of July 24, advocate Ariful Islam, 28, was standing near the site of a NEET paper leak protest in Guwahati when policemen stopped by and took him into custody. They later registered his arrest at 9 p.m. on that day.

"What is most alarming is that, at the time of his detention, he (Mr. Islam) was in the court dress of an advocate and repeatedly identified himself as a member of the Bar, producing his Bar Council identity card before the police personnel present at the spot," read a statement issued by the Assam unit of the All India Lawyers Association for Justice.

The arrested advocate, it added, was merely a bystander at the protest venue in Guwahati.

On the same day, 23-year-old Mustahid Ahmed was also arrested after he reportedly asked a policeman outside the protest venue why his name tag was missing from his uniform.

Mr. Islam and Mr. Ahmed were two of five persons held in Guwahati on that day. The other three were Chinmoy Deka, a 24-year-old student, and



Security personnel detaining a demonstrator protesting against the NEET paper leak in Guwahati on July 25. ANI

food delivery agents Amir Ali, 26, and Mehdi Alam, 26. A member of the lawyers' association said the two food delivery agents had nothing to do with the protest.

The Assam government has now withdrawn five cases leading to the arrest of 13 people who participated in the protests against the NEET examination paper leak, announcing that the "matter shall be treated as closed".

In an order issued late Monday night, the police said no adverse action would be taken against the protesters. It also said the process to review the arrest of the 13 people picked up on July 23 and 24 was being expedited.

The Guwahati arrests came a day after a Students' Federation of India

(SFI) protest on July 23 in solidarity with activist Sonam Wangchuk and agitating students nationwide seeking education reforms.

Among the others, three students were arrested in Lakhimpur, while Congress leader Birinchi Bora was held in Nagazon town.

Most of them were booked under penal sections dealing with criminal conspiracy; endangering the sovereignty, unity and integrity of India; endangering human life or personal safety; using criminal force to stop a public servant from doing his or her job; wrongful confinement; rioting and unlawful assembly; and publishing or circulating false statements.

The government's latest decision followed the release of more than 50 people detained on July 25.

Echoes of Jantar Mantar in U.P. as 'Gen Alpha' school students stage protest for basic facilities

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Days after the Cockroach Janta Party-led student protest in Delhi drew national attention, a similar expression of dissent emerged from Uttar Pradesh's Fatehpur district on Tuesday, when hundreds of students at a government-aided school walked out of their classrooms and staged a protest demanding better infrastructure.

The school administration called police personnel to maintain order.

Videos from the protest, which gained wider attention after being shared by Chandrashekhar Azad, Nagina MP and president of the Azad Samaj Party (Kanshi Ram), and Aam Aadmi Party, show police asking students to clear the road, even as the demonstrators continue marching.



Students said midday meals had never been served as per rules. SPECIAL ARRANGMENT

The demonstration took place at Sarvodaya Inter College, a government-aided school with nearly 1,800 students, in Kishanpur town. Students marched through the locality holding portraits of B.R. Ambedkar and carrying placards that read: 'College ki vyavastha sudharo, bachchon ka bhavishya samwaro' (Improve the college's condition, secure the future of its students).

Abhishek Sonkar, a student, alleged that midday meals had never been served in accordance with the prescribed menu.

In his post, the Nagina MP alleged that repeated representations to the school administration had failed to bring about any meaningful change. He concluded the post with the slogan, 'Jai Bhim! Jai Gen Alpha!'

'Attended Delhi protest' Principal of the school, L.B. Singh, told *The Hindu* that several demands, including the installation of four fans in each classroom, a water cooler and the provision of meals as per the prescribed menu, had been addressed immediately. He added that a few students from the higher grades were learnt to have participated in the protest at Jantar Mantar.

Students involved in NEET paper leak agitation facing police crackdown, says AISA

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The All India Students' Association (AISA) on Tuesday alleged that protesters involved in the agitation against the NEET paper leak are facing a police crackdown across the country.

The students' body claimed that multiple SFI activists, including former JNUSU president Dhananjay, AISA Bihar secretary Dipankar Mishra, and Patna University activists Divyanshu Kumar and Saba Aftab, have been arrested in Bihar.

AISA national president Neha, one of the prominent faces during the protest, said during a press conference at the Press Club of India: "We were assured that students protesting peacefully would not face



AISA national president Neha (left) and DU unit secretary Anjali addressing the media in New Delhi on Tuesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

repression. However, what we have witnessed is continued arrests, arbitrary detentions and intimidation of students across the country. The government must uphold its promises, release those detained and engage with the concerns of students."

In addition to arrests made in Bihar, West Bengal and Jharkhand, AISA said that protesters were sent notices in Delhi's Jamia Na-

gar. "It has come to our notice that in Jamia Nagar, student peostesters are being sent notices based on retina and face scanning for their presence at Jantar Mantar. AISA Jamia has issued a helpline for legal aid in the matter," AISA said in a statement.

The organisation reiterated its demand to release all protesters and give compensation for those injured in police brutality.

Withdraw all cases against students: Pinarayi to Kerala CM

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Leader of the Opposition in Kerala Assembly Pinarayi Vijayan has written to Chief Minister V.D. Sathesan demanding an unconditional withdrawal of all cases filed in the State against those who took to the streets to express solidarity with the Jantar Mantar students' agitation.

The office of the Chief Minister on Tuesday informed that Mr. Vijayan's letter has been forwarded to the Home Department for further action.

In his letter, Mr. Vijayan said that

while the Chief Minister himself was seen joining the protests at Jantar Mantar, alongside the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, it is inappropriate that the very government he leads in

Reports indicate that the police have booked cases against nearly 5,000 people for staging protests

Kerala has charge-sheeted many who agitated in Kerala to support the students.

He also pointed out that there are complaints that false cases were being foisted against many who took part in peaceful protests.

Reports indicate that the Kerala police have booked cases against nearly 5,000 people across various parts of the State for participating in these protests. As the Centre has agreed to withdraw all cases against students, the United Democratic Front government should not delay in withdrawing the cases filed by the Kerala police, Mr. Vijayan said.

BJP bids to stave off JSP, RJD challenge as campaigning ends for Bankipur byelection

Amit Bhehari
PATNA

Campaigning for the July 30 Bankipur Assembly byelection in Bihar came to a close on Tuesday, with candidates making a final push to secure the seat vacated by BJP national president Nitin Nabin following his election to the Rajya Sabha in April.

The BJP is making an all-out effort to retain the seat and has fielded 32-year-old youth wing leader Neeraj Kumar Sinha as its candidate. The bypoll will mark the electoral debut of Prashant Kishor, the 49-year-old founder of the Jan Suraj Party (JSP), which failed to win any seat in the Assembly poll last year.

The Opposition Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) has nominated Rekha Kumari,



JSP candidate Prashant Kishor addressing a rally and BJP's Neeraj Kumar Sinha meeting voters in Bankipur on Tuesday. AMIT BHEHARI

who was the runner-up from the seat in the Assembly poll that was won by Mr. Nabin by a margin of over 50,000 votes. RJD working president Tejash Yadav joined the party's campaign only on Monday.

Although 25 candidates are in the fray, the contest appears to be primarily between the BJP and the



JSP. The Bankipur constituency has nearly four lakh voters. The Kayastha and Yadav communities together account for about 25% of the electorate. Muslims and Chandravanshis also have sizeable numbers, with both communities constituting nearly 20% of the voters. The Vaishya, Dalit, Bhumihar, Rajput,

Brahmin, Kurmi, and Kushwaha communities each make up between 3% and 8% of the electorate.

Key concerns

On the BJP candidate's roadshow, Sanjay Gupta, a trader from Meethapur, said, "We are not looking at caste; for us, the candidate is more important."

Voters also expressed concern over issues such as the NEET paper leak row and alleged theft of donations at Ram Temple.

Mr. Kishor addressed public meetings in Peermuhani, Sabailgah, and Jai Prakash Nagar. Speaking to the gathering at Peermuhani, the JSP leader said, "When you go to cast the vote, think about the future of your children."

The results will be declared on August 3.

Rain, reflections on Jantar Mantar protest mark Day 1 of DU's new academic session

Antra Abhilasha
NEW DELHI

Delhi University's (DU) new academic session opened on Tuesday to familiar sights — nervous freshers, returning seniors, and long registration queues.

Amid rain and low attendance, campuses buzzed with conversations around the recently concluded protest at Jantar Mantar.

Many who watched the stir unfold from outside Delhi or stayed back out of concern for their safety said they regretted not being present on the ground.

With the DU students' union elections approaching, student organisations also began their campaigns with help desks and pamphlet distribution. Some students questioned the absence of the RSS-linked



Students of Miranda House enjoying the rain on Tuesday, the first day of Delhi University's new academic session. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) from the agitation. The ABVP had earlier defended its position, saying it was raising students' issues through platforms other than the Jantar Mantar protest.

Outside the gates of Shri Ram College of Commerce, Soundarya, a fresher, expressed regret at not hav-

ing attended the stir at Jantar Mantar. "I couldn't join the protest due to security concerns. It was a much-needed movement and I stand in support of the students who raised their voices," she said.

Outside Daulat Ram College, Divya Dewana, a third-year student, reflected on watching the protest

unfold. "Seeing all the students, the Gen Z, come together was a good feeling. Everyone was speaking up for their rights, about what they found wrong, and asking for change," she said.

'Take strict action'

At the orientation session in the college, Shubhi Yadav, a third-year student, spoke about the brutality she witnessed. "Policemen harassed women and even beat schoolchildren. A child in Class 6 suffered a fractured leg," she said.

"Labelling students demanding their right to education as 'anti-nationals' is unjust in a democracy. Strict action must be taken against the misconduct by the police," she added.

A teacher said fewer students attended orientation sessions due to the rain.

RSS distances itself from Kerala Hindutva ideologue's remarks

The Hindu Bureau
KOCCHI

The Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh has condemned the controversial remarks made by Hindutva ideologue T.G. Mohandas against the student protests at Jantar Mantar.

In a video posted on his YouTube channel, Mr. Mo-

handas had said that he "would have shot" the protesters if he were in control.

A former head of the BJP's Kerala intellectual cell, he said in another video that secular women who take part in protests "enjoy being gangraped."

K.B. Sreekumar, Saha Pranthan Karyavah (South

Kerala) of the RSS, said in a statement that Mr. Mohandas's comments on the protests were "his personal thoughts and he is not an RSS official at any level".

He said the RSS did not agree with his views and "such views should be condemned in every highest possible manner".

Kerala teen affected by amoebic brain infection critical

The Hindu Bureau
KASARAGOD

Kasaragod district in Kerala has reported another case of amoebic menin-

goencephalitis (amoebic brain infection), with an 18-year-old testing positive for the rare but life-threatening disease. The teenager is in a critical condition at the

intensive care unit of a hospital in Mangaluru.

According to preliminary information, the teen had bathed, along with his friends, in a pond located

along the Kanhangad-Panathur State highway about a week ago. He developed health complications soon afterwards, and subsequent tests con-

firmed the infection. The Health Department and the police issued a warning directing people not to bathe in the pond until further notice.

CGHIDB
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Tenders shall download tender from ege-procurement website.

- Date and Time of Pre-bid meeting:- at 12:00 PM on 06.08.2026 at Sector-19, Paryawas Bhawan, CGHIDB Head Office, Nava Raipur Atal Nagar
- Last Date and Time of online Pre-bid queries submission- on or before the above mentioned date & time.
- Last Date for Online submission of Tender- Till 03:00 PM on 13.08.2026

Note: Email id for submission of pre bid queries: cgbbdiv03@gmail.com

The details of tender and terms & conditions are available on the e-Procurement website <https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>. Any amendment/corrigendum in the tender documents, will only be uploaded on the e-Procurement website and shall not be published in any newspaper.

Samvad-48569/5 E.E, CGHIDB, Div-3 Raipur

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

OBITUARY

Shri. Balaram Venkataraman (86)
Cousin, eternal Sargam on July 21, 2026.
-In mourning-
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Oni Shanthi

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Tender Notice No. EL-MWS-GKP-2026-27-08. Description of work: Provision of Copper Shrouded Bus Bar System at Fiat Bogie Shop in Mechanical Workshop, Gorakhpur. Approx. Value: ₹ 25,37,472/-, E.M.D. Money: ₹ 50,800/-. Cost of Tender Document: 0.00, Completion time Period from the date of issue of acceptance letter: 02 Months.
• E-tender online will be submitted upto 11:00 hrs. on dated 17-08-2026.
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ई-निविदा सूचना

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म.प्र. माध्यम/127225/2026

संचालक

BIHAR SCHOOL EXAMINATION BOARD
NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER
Tender Notice No. : PR 171/2026

Bihar School Examination Board invites e-tenders under two bid systems from the reputed, experienced Firms/Companies/Agencies/ Societies for "Supply & Printing of Variable Data on Pre-printed Blank Stationery Provided by BSEB and Tabulation Register for Matric and Inter Examination (Annual & Compartmental)-2027 & Other Examinations." Detailed tender document containing eligibility criteria, other terms and conditions are available on the website <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in>

Tender Schedule	
Date and Time for Activity	Date/Time/ Duration
Online Sale/ Download Date of Tender Documents	From: 29/07/2026 (16:00 Hrs.) to 19/08/2026 (16:00 Hrs.) (https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
Pre-Bid Meeting	07/08/2026 at 12:30 Hrs. (Bihar School Examination Board, Sinha Library Road, Patna-800017)
Last Date/ Time for Submission/ uploading of Online Bid	19/08/2026 up to 16:00 Hrs. (https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
Last Date and Time for Submission of EMD (Only in case of BG) / Samples	20/08/2026 up to 13:00 Hrs.
Date & Time for Opening of Technical Bid	20/08/2026 at 14:00 Hrs (https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
Date & Time for Opening of Financial Bid	Date to be announced later by Competent Authority.
Cost of the Tender Document	₹5,900/- (Five Thousand Nine Hundred Rupees Only) (Non-Refundable)
Tender Processing Fee	₹5,900/- (Five Thousand Nine Hundred Rupees Only) (Non-Refundable)
Earnest Money	₹1,00,000/- (One Lakh Rupees only) (Refundable)

* Contact Details: Nodal Officer, Mobile No. : +91 62995 23095, E-Mail ID: eproc-bseb-bih@gov.in / eproc.bseb@gmail.com

* Note: Bihar School Examination Board reserves the right to accept/ cancel/ reschedule tenders without assigning any reasons. Prospective bidders are advised to regularly visit <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in>, Corrigendum/ Amendments etc., if any, will be notified on this portal only and no separate advertisement will be made.

Secretary

HIMACHAL PRADESH PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT "CORRIGENDUM"

The time schedule for the work namely "Up-gradation of Link road Rait Neri Balla Salwana- Tatvani Km. 0/00 to 17/048 (Portion 10/970 to 17/048) in Dist. Kangra (HP) (SH-Improvement, passing places, RW/Val, CD work, GSI, WBH-I, Tarring work, Paver Block, Side drains/pipes and road sign etc.) including five year routine Maintenance), (under NABARD RIDF-XXXI) as called vide this office No. PW/D/SEV WS-VI NABARD/ RIDF-XXXI 2026-27 2625-35 dated 08/07/2026 is hereby extended, due to some Technical/ Administrative reasons. The following key dates may be read as:-

Job No.	Dates already mentioned	Now may be read as
1.	Start date of downloading of bid: 15/07/2026 (10:00 AM)	25.07.2026 (10.00AM)
2.	Deadline for submission of bid: 28/07/2026 (5:00 PM)	15/08/2026 (05.00PM)
3.	Date of opening tenders: 29/07/2026 (11:30 AM)	17.08.2026 (11.30AM)

Others terms and conditions will remain unchanged. The bidders are advised to note other details of tenders from the departmental website <https://tenders.gov.in>.

Superintending Engineer, 5th Circle, HP PWD, Palampur.

HP / 2221/26-27 HIM SUCHANA AVAM JAN SAMPARK

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Sr. No.	Office & Type of Work	Estimated Cost (Rs. in Lacs)
1.	Unit Head, Kota	
11	Development Works at Industrial Area Growth Park Deroli, Bundi. UIN-RCDC27W50B01029	941.07
12	Development Works at IGP Top Park, Rangpur, Kota. UIN-RCDC27W50B00958	301.47
2.	Unit Head, Jaipur	
21	Improvement of Civil Infrastructure at Industrial Area IIS Center Newai, Distt. Tonk. UIN-RCDC27W50B00933	903.45
3.	Unit Head, Jaipur	
31	Construction of C Road & Paving Road Shoulders with Interlocking CC Blocks at Industrial Area Bagru, Distt. Jaipur. UIN-RCDC27W50B00903	638.63
4.	Unit Head, Nagpur	
41	Construction of Road & C/P Works and RCC Plot Demarcation Pillars at Ind Area Chhinwar Nagar. UIN-RCDC27W50B00926	295.73
5.	Unit Head, Jaipur	
51	Removal and Re-laying of Precast Interlocking Tiles and Raising and Covering of Existing Drains at Industrial Area Apparel Park, Jaipur. UIN-RCDC27W50B00907	335.01
6.	Unit Head, Ajmer	
61	Development of Scheme Mandi at Mothi, Ichil Badnor, Ajmer. UIN-RCDC27W50B001019	226.80
7.	Unit Head, Jaipur	
71	Development Works at Industrial Area Sameli (Dausa). UIN-RCDC27W50B00909	297.22
8.	Unit Head, Jaipur	
81	Improvement of Drainage Network on Approach Road at Industrial Area Bagru (Ratla), Jaipur. UIN-RCDC27W50B00974	344.89
9.	Unit Head, Mandla	
91	Development Works at Industrial Area IGP Hajigarh, Ichil Area, Distt. Phalodi. UIN-RCDC27W50B00100	949.67

Bidders/contractors may download and submit tender online. Detailed information of tenders and any kind of corrigendum/ date extension, if any in future, may be seen by bidders on websites eproc.rajasthan.gov.in and www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in. For queries please contact: CMI (Civil) Ph. 0141-4593214 R/S:Samvedi/17/26/1905

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3	Deputy Manager (Safety)	No. CSL/P&A/ RHM/HRM/ MANPOWER/ 2025/91 (A), (B) and (C) dated 24 July 2026	1 Post	Ship Repair Facilities at Kanari/ Visakhapatnam
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5	Manager (Environment)		1 Post	CSL, Kochi
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GENERAL MANAGER (HR & LD)

Editorial



Protecting protest

Protests that inconvenience people must not be confused with violence

Defining feature of the recent Cockerroach Janta Party agitation related to its under-estimation by the government, which hoped to quell the protests by force. The net result was widespread student anger, which served to entrench the agitation. The Supreme Court has just commenced hearing petitions on the police's alleged use of disproportionate force, especially on July 25 in Delhi and a constable's aerial firing of an assault rifle allegedly to disperse crowds on July 25 in Bihar's Siwan. The Court has also agreed to hear petitions from the families of police personnel claiming that they were assaulted and "lynched". The ferocity of the July 20 police crackdown against protesters is not in doubt; in addition to tear gas, videos also purported to show the police using lathis studded with nails. But as Justice Joyimalya Bagchi observed, the state should also answer why some police officers allegedly lacked protective gear. Under-equipped police are more likely to escalate force out of fear, and this is why international best practices in crowd control involve graduated responses. There is also merit in pleas that the same police force accused of using excess force also investigating it could potentially undermine credibility.

However, the Chief Justice of India's remark that protests are permissible "with due permission and at designated places" could come at odds with the right to protest. The democratic purpose of a protest is to inconvenience the state and thus should not be limited to its happening at the state's convenience. At the same time, not every inconvenience is constitutionally protected. The answer lies in proportionality. If the CJJ's insistence on "discipline" comes to mean protests must be orderly and predictable, it risks imposing administrative preferences on a constitutional right. The state is responsible for preventing violence, protecting life, and maintaining essential services. But modern cities are also dense and even a peaceful blockade could deprive thousands of uninvolved citizens of their liberties. The judiciary should thus resist conflating disruption that results in inconveniencing the public – which is one of the mechanisms by which a protest acquires its political force – and violence, which infringes on the rights of others. A unified set of procedures will also be welcome since policing is a State subject under the Seventh Schedule, and States have different training, equipment, escalation, and documentation rules. A national protocol could standardise the thresholds at which the use of high-impact crowd-control measures can be authorised and mandatory documentation of lathi charges, medical assistance after use of force, preservation of evidence, and independent inquiries into serious injuries.

Diminishing relevance

The Commonwealth Games look increasingly like a relic from the past

As Olympic and World Championships medalist Mirabai Chanu stood atop the podium in Glasgow on Sunday, tears rolling down her cheeks after becoming the first woman weightlifter to secure her third consecutive Commonwealth Games gold medal, she provided much-needed succour to a Games that had risked fading into oblivion a few years ago. With India set to host the centenary edition of the Games in Ahmedabad in 2030, there could not have been a better advertisement than Mirabai's golden triumph, which also ensured her fourth medal of any colour in a row in the women's 48kg category with a total of 190kg. The seasoned weightlifter's feat may not be the only glorious chapter written in the Scottish city, as other leading Indian athletes are expected to climb the podium in athletics and para-athletics, weightlifting and para-weightlifting, boxing, judo, and lawn bowls and para-bowls. According to an internal estimation by the Union Sports Ministry, India's athletes are expected to win around 30 medals even though several disciplines in which Indians have traditionally excelled – such as wrestling, badminton, table tennis, hockey and squash – were dropped from the scaled-down Glasgow event. Medals are expected from Neeraj Chopra, Murali Sreeshankar, Praveen Chithravel, and boxers Lovlina Borgohain and Jaismine Lamboria.

The curtailed Commonwealth Games highlights the diminishing relevance of the erstwhile British Empire's sporting tradition. The 2026 edition, originally allotted to Victoria, faced an existential threat after the Australian State withdrew as a host three years ago due to spiralling costs. Glasgow, the host in 2014, saved the Games from embarrassment by proposing a scaled-down version – with 10 integrated disciplines, across four venues within an eight-mile corridor. Even though the Commonwealth Games do not match the global or regional excellence of the Olympics or the Asian Games, the platform still holds a strong appeal for Indian sportspersons and administrators. While India's success at the elite world level across different sports has been sporadic, it has the dubious distinction of topping the global doping charts for three successive years. Multiple athletes across disciplines have been caught for consuming banned substances even in the run-up to Glasgow 2026. Either they have been withdrawn from the Indian contingent or have failed to qualify due to this, impacting the nation's medal chances and bringing it shameful international headlines. As the country prepares to organise a bigger Commonwealth Games – especially against the backdrop of the corruption-tainted Delhi 2010 edition – it would do well to enhance its vigilance to curb financial malpractices and promote clean sport over the next four years.

On June 22, 2026, 15 people gasped at death in a burning building in Aliganj, Lucknow. Trapped behind smoke-filled corridors and sealed exits, they never had a chance. The commercial establishment operating from a residential neighbourhood was a veritable death trap – pigeonhole-sized workstations crammed into an unauthorised structure with no viable fire escape.

It was not merely a building that caught fire, but a system that failed. A tragedy waiting to happen, aided by those whose job it was to prevent it.

All this happened, while the TV channels discussed animatedly U.S.-Iran parleys, where India played no role, and analysts dissected the number of Members of Parliament defecting to the Eknath Shivde-led Shiv Sena. Not aware if there was ever a mention of a collapse of political ethics and morality. But then, do ethics, morality and professionalism figure in urban governance today? Major fires have erupted in cities across India in 2026 on account of failures of urban regulation – signifying abject greed and mismanagement.

On June 3, a fire in a bed and breakfast facility, Malviya Nagar, Delhi, was also caused by illegal construction with no emergency exit. In February, a Bhiwadi garment plant, Rajasthan, which caught fire was an illegal firecracker-manufacturing unit behind closed doors; the fire in a cracker manufacturing unit in Virudhunagar, Tamil Nadu, took place when the factory was running illegally on a Sunday.

Yet, amidst the horror, emerged stories of extraordinary courage. In Delhi's Malviya Nagar fire, a mattress shop owner reportedly emptied his entire stock onto the street to cushion those jumping from the burning building. Young residents rushed forward without waiting for instructions, while police personnel administered CPR, evacuated victims and continued rescue efforts despite injuries to themselves. Such acts of humanity stand in sharp contrast to the institutional failures.

Historical data trends suggest that India sees approximately 13,000-15,000 fire deaths annually, with the summer of 2026 projected to be one of the worst due to extreme heatwaves triggering electrical fires. In the first quarter of 2026, 39 people have died in fires in Delhi alone, even before the summer peak began.

Violations without consequences

The problem extends far beyond Aliganj and Malviya Nagar. Death traps of varying forms exist in countless urban settlements across India. They may differ in appearance but share a common characteristic: everyone knows the violations exist, yet they continue.

This is what makes the present crisis particularly troubling when India today possesses technological capabilities unimaginable even a decade ago. Satellite imagery can identify encroachments. Drones can map illegal



Yashovardhan Azad

Retired Indian Police Service officer, who has served as the Central Information Commissioner, Secretary – Security, Government of India, and Special Director, Intelligence Bureau

constructions. Geographic Information Systems can track land use changes. Digital property databases can identify violations. Artificial intelligence can flag anomalies and real-time dashboards can monitor compliance.

Is it really difficult for a municipal commissioner, a development authority official, a State government functionary or the Lieutenant Governor to call for a list of establishments operating without licences, fire clearances or in myriad violations of building norms?

The difficulty lies elsewhere. It lies in political pressure and vote-bank calculations and in the thriving informal economies that governments are reluctant to confront and where urban laws and regulations are routinely violated. But, most importantly, it lies in corruption.

Could the fire in Lucknow have been averted? Yes. In 2016, a notice for demolition was given but within two months was withdrawn. It was clearly a political decision. The property stood out as a symbol of political patronage under benign oversight of officials, right in the midst of a prominent locality of the capital. This sends out a message to the lower officials, the enforcers, who then entrench a system of their own beneficiaries, overlooking various violations for monetary benefits.

The Special Investigation Team (SIT) formed to investigate the fire comprised two senior officers, from the IAS and the IPS from the State of Uttar Pradesh, with the report to be submitted to another IAS officer of the government. The head of Lucknow land development Authority is also an IAS officer. In such a situation, can the inquiry yield anything purposeful. If a calamity of this kind results only in a conversation between a closed loop of bureaucrats, can there ever be any meaningful reform? No. But it was certainly possible if the Minister of Urban Development and the head of the capital land development authority were indicted for this tragedy.

This pattern is visible across the country. In Noida, a young professional lost his life after falling into a waterlogged, poorly protected urban hazard. In Indore, celebrated nationally for cleanliness, deaths linked to contaminated water supply raise disturbing questions about basic civic safeguards. Bengaluru, India's technology capital, repeatedly grinds to a halt after heavy rains. Mumbai, India's financial capital, continues to struggle with flooding despite decades of investment and repeated expert recommendations.

A common thread

Different cities. Different governments. Different political parties, but the same outcome. The real concern is the absence of accountability and governance deficit. What happened after Delhi's basement coaching centre tragedy? Arrests were made. Committees were constituted. Headlines were generated. Yet, illegal and unsafe basement operations continue to flourish in many cities. How many inquiry reports have fundamentally

Urban neglect, political apathy, and corruption continue to claim lives across India

Iran's Afghan balancing act amid regional upheaval

The funeral proceedings of Iran's late Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, that stretched over a week amid a spiralling war and significant internal turmoil at the seat of power for Shiism, saw multiple personalities visit Tehran. Almost unnoticed, however, was the presence of delegations from both the Taliban and the opposition Northern Alliance. The two have been fighting each other, in various iterations, over Afghanistan since the 1990s.

Complex equations

The presence of the Taliban's Deputy Prime Minister for Economic Affairs Mullah Abdul Ghani Baradar along with Taliban Foreign Minister Amir Khan Muttaqi on the one hand and the Northern Alliance's Ahmed Massoud, son of the group's founder Ahmed Shah Massoud on the other, highlighted the delicate game of geopolitics that continues to persist on Tehran's eastern front. While Iran is the one country which has built the strongest influence with Kabul since the collapse of the government of President Ashraf Ghani (August 2021), it still does not officially recognise the Taliban government. This is hardly surprising, considering that until the 1990s, Iran, along with India, Russia, Tajikistan and other neighbouring and foreign states, supported the Northern Alliance.

The chaotic withdrawal of the United States from Afghanistan, in August 2021, two decades after a post-9/11 war launched against al Qaeda was a critical moment in Tehran. The consistent and massive deployment of western military power on its borders was a perpetual nightmare that had to be factored into its calculations. Pakistan's support for and incubation of the Afghan Taliban, while simultaneously backing the U.S.-led "war on terror", created a sinkhole of competing interests, where the Venn diagram of who was supporting whom became so



Kabir Taneja

Executive Director of the Observer Research Foundation Middle East

convoluted that foreign powers often ceded the upper hand to regional players. The fact that al Qaeda founder Osama Bin Laden was eventually found in Abbottabad, Pakistan (May 2011), in a large house – and not a cave in the infamous Tora Bora – was not a coincidence.

The Afghan chessboard

The Iranian viewpoint on the Taliban and the Afghan landscape changed significantly after 9/11. While Tehran remains sceptical of the Taliban and the future of its rule to this day, it simultaneously recognises that an insurgency-turned-government will always carry a question mark over its long-term stability. The ideological and tribal fissures that persist also require micromanagement, which means creating enemies along volatile borders is not in anyone's long-term interests.

Following 2021, the Taliban was in search of both power and patronage. Iran could offer some of the power, but only a limited amount of the patronage. The calculation behind this was to free up a major front from as much conflict as possible. The Northern Alliance, largely concentrated in the mountainous northern province of Panjshir, was both weak and disorganised, with infighting having hollowed out any possibility of cohesion and structure. In fact, since February, as clouds of war gathered, the Taliban reiterated that it would support Iran should the country come under attack. Zabihtullah Mujahid, a spokesman close to Taliban Emir Hibatullah Akhundzada, said in an interview with Iranian state radio that they would support Iran if need be. The nature and extent of such support, of course, remain subjects of debate. Diplomatic support from Kabul has been robust over the past year, including access to the country's civilian airports.

But the Iranians hosting Masoud and the Northern Alliance delegation in Tehran shows

altered urban governance? How many officials have faced meaningful consequences years after disasters? How many systemic reforms have followed repeated tragedies? India has actually become adept at managing outrage and far less effective in preventing a recurrence of man-made tragedies.

At the heart of the problem lies a governance structure that nobody wishes to discuss honestly. For over three decades, since the 74th Constitutional Amendment, India has spoken of empowering urban local bodies. Yet, most city governments remain weak. Every Chief Minister is the de facto mayor for all cities in his/her State and municipal corporations have responsibility without authority. Elected representatives have visibility without power. Important functions remain scattered across development authorities, municipal corporations, public works departments, water boards, transport agencies and numerous specialised bodies.

A flooded road belongs to one agency, a drain to another, land to a third and enforcement to a fourth. Citizens, meanwhile, simply see government. This fragmentation has created a dangerous accountability vacuum.

Fix governance first

The answer therefore is not another scheme. Indian cities are already overflowing with schemes, missions, projects and programmes. Every few years a new initiative comes up with a new acronym and fresh funding. The problem is not the absence of schemes, but the absence of governance. A number of well-meaning schemes lie buried under corruption and mismanagement. Cities require empowered local institutions, professional urban management, clear accountability and fearless enforcement. Technology must become an instrument of compliance rather than a showcase of modernisation. Most importantly, governments must find the political courage to dismantle entrenched systems of tolerated illegality. Officers, the enforcers, look away fearing a clash with political vested interests.

The victims of Lucknow and Delhi fires did not die because India lacks fire safety laws. They died despite those laws. That is the distinction policymakers must understand. Urban governance is ultimately measured not by the number of projects inaugurated, smart-city dashboards installed or schemes announced, but by the number of tragedies prevented. The real test of governance is whether an ordinary citizen can work, live, study, shop or sleep in a building without fear of dying because somebody chose to ignore the rules.

Will this tragedy become yet another file, another enquiry and another forgotten headline? Or will it finally compel us to confront the uncomfortable truth that India's cities are not merely growing beyond their capacity but are increasingly failing the very citizens they were meant to serve?

The events of 2021 on Iran's eastern front continue to influence Tehran's choices amid the war in 2026

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Protest to politics

The Cockerroach Janta Party's threat that fresh protests could erupt if the terms of the agreement with the government are not met may not find many takers, even among the youth and students. It should not be under the impression that all its protests will succeed.

The ruling dispensation has the power to quell unrest. Now that some political leaders have identified themselves with the BJP, it may develop a stronger political dependence for its survival. One would not be surprised if the BJP announces itself as a political party soon (Front

page, July 28).
V. Lakshmanan,
Tirupur, Tamil Nadu

Restore trust

The Union Government's decision to constitute a high-level task force is a welcome acknowledgement of the deep crisis of confidence surrounding

India's examination and higher education system. Equally reassuring is the appointment of Nandan Nilekani as its chair. His leadership in building Aadhaar and India's digital public infrastructure demonstrates his ability to combine technological innovation with institutional

reform. His vision can help the task force prepare India's education system for the demands of a rapidly evolving knowledge economy. However, the committee's success will depend on more than recommendations. The government must ensure transparent

implementation, clear timelines, measurable outcomes, and regular public accountability to restore trust among millions of aspiring students.

M. Jayaram,
Sholavandan, Tamil Nadu

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Co-existing with tigers outside reserves

India's tiger conservation story is widely regarded as one of the world's most extraordinary wildlife recoveries – a species brought back from near extinction through sustained political commitment, scientific management, and decades of on-ground protection. Since the launch of Project Tiger in 1973, the country's network of protected areas has expanded from nine reserves covering 18,278 sq km to 58 reserves spanning 84,488 sq km, accounting for nearly 2.6% of India's landmass. India's tiger population has risen from 1,411 in 2006 to 3,682 in 2022, firmly establishing the country as home to over 70% of the world's wild tigers. This success has now created a new conservation frontier – the growing proportion of tigers living outside protected areas.

Although national datasets do not conclusively link rising tiger numbers with increasing human-tiger conflict, forest departments across several landscapes report a steady escalation in such incidents. As territorial carnivores require extensive home ranges, tigers disperse naturally when core habitats reach saturation. Consequently, more tigers are moving beyond protected boundaries into human-dominated fringes. According to the National Tiger Conservation Authority, 35-40% of India's tiger population now lives outside designated Tiger Reserves. This reality has prompted the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change to launch the Tigers Outside Tiger Reserves (TOTR) initiative.

Beyond protected boundaries
The growing tiger population reflects healthy breeding groups, functional habitats, and well-connected forest corridors. However, when tigers move beyond protected areas into landscapes interwoven with villages, farms, roads and other human infrastructure, interactions



Supriya Sahu

is a senior administrator currently serving in the Government of Tamil Nadu. She has worked extensively on environmental policy, ecosystem restoration, wildlife and biodiversity conservation, climate action and human-wildlife coexistence. She is the recipient of the UNEP Champions of the Earth Award 2025

with people become inevitable, leading to human fatalities, livestock depredation, accidental encounters, prolonged rescue operations, and heightened public anxiety. Each incident carries ecological, social, and political consequences, placing enormous pressure on forest departments and district administrations.

The objective of the TOTR is to establish a scientifically grounded, landscape-based framework for conserving tigers outside protected areas while safeguarding human lives and livelihoods. Rather than responding to conflict only after it occurs, the initiative seeks to shift the approach from reactive crisis management to proactive, science-driven governance built on technology, preparedness, and community participation.

The TOTR is being launched as a targeted pilot rather than a nationwide rollout, recognising that long-term policy must be anchored in evidence generated under real field conditions.

The All-India Tiger Estimation (2022) recorded tiger presence across 212 forest divisions. Based on this assessment, 40 forest divisions across nine States have been selected for the first phase of the TOTR implementation. The participating States include Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Telangana and Assam.

The TOTR rests on two complementary pillars. The first focuses on reducing human-tiger conflict and strengthening field protection. This includes upgrading communication systems, deploying rapid response teams, improving rescue infrastructure, and ensuring coordinated action during emergencies. The second pillar emphasises long-term coexistence. Conservation outside protected areas cannot succeed without the trust and participation of local communities. Awareness programmes, community engagement, timely compensation

and treating villagers as partners are central to the initiative. Tigers and people now co-occur across vast shared landscapes, making structured coexistence essential for long-term stability.

Among these, streamlined and timely compensation mechanisms are critical. Although States have their own frameworks, delays often erode public trust and fuel resentment. States must simplify procedures and invest in sustained outreach to build confidence among rural families living alongside tigers.

The role of States

Participating States will also need to invest strategically in both technology and institutional capacity. The programme rightly emphasises the use of modern conservation tools such as camera traps, GPS-enabled monitoring systems, drones and AI to strengthen surveillance, improve early warning systems and enable evidence-based decision-making. However, technology alone cannot resolve human-tiger conflict. Its effectiveness will ultimately depend on the strength of the institutions that support it. Building public confidence requires well-trained forest staff, veterinarians, and rescue teams capable of responding rapidly in conflict situations.

The TOTR underscores a broader national imperative: strengthening the governance of shared landscapes where ecological processes and human livelihoods intersect daily. The initiative signals a shift from viewing tiger conservation solely through the lens of protected areas to recognising the wider mosaic of reserve forests and other lands that now support dispersing tigers.

If executed with the same determination that made Project Tiger a global benchmark, the TOTR could become India's defining conservation initiative of the century proving that people and large carnivores can share space safely.

Need for moderation in public speech

Tamil Nadu's political arena has become a theatre of vitriolic discourse

STATE OF PLAY

M.S. Shanmugam

Mark Twain once said, "the difference between the almost right word and the right word is really a large matter."

In recent times, public discourse in Tamil Nadu's political arena has come under scrutiny. Concerns are being raised across sections of society about the tone, content, and quality of speeches delivered by leaders from both the ruling and Opposition parties. Allegations, counter-allegations, legal actions, agitated debates on television channels and newspapers have become frequent, indicating not merely isolated incidents, but a worrying trend.

Political speech is not just a tool for mobilisation; it is a reflection of democratic culture. Furthermore, it is one of the most basic tools and features of democracy. It is how parties take their policies and views to the people. However, when language descends into personal attacks, provocation, or sensationalism, it sets a precedent. And a bad one at that.

History teaches us that while such precedents are easy to establish, they are exceedingly difficult to reverse.

Global precedents

The experience of the United States during the McCarthy era in the 1950s offers a telling lesson. Senator Joseph McCarthy's speeches, marked by sweeping allegations and dramatic accusations, created a climate of fear and mistrust. Careers were ruined, institutions were strained, and public discourse suffered.



It took a moment of collective introspection – captured in the famous question, "Have you no sense of decency, sir?" – to begin restoring balance. The damage, however, lingered far beyond that moment.

Similarly, in Europe, the final years of the Weimar Republic saw a steady decline in the quality of political speech. Increasingly harsh and polarising rhetoric eroded mutual respect among political actors and weakened democratic norms. What began as verbal aggression eventually contributed to a breakdown of stability itself.

The lesson was clear: words, when used unchecked, can shape outcomes far beyond immediate political gains.

Leaders shape discourse

In a mature democracy, citizens expect more from their leaders. They look for clarity of vision rather than clever invective; for solutions rather than slogans; and for dignity even in disagreement.

Political speech must inform, inspire, and unify – not inflame or divide. The divisive and exclusive, as opposed to inclusive, trends in speeches are causing deep concerns at the local as well as the global level.

Moderation in speech is

not a sign of weakness; it is a mark of strength and responsibility. It reflects confidence in one's ideas and respect for the audience. When there is solid substance, the words spoken become the natural foundation on which to reach the people.

Leaders at all levels set the tone for public behaviour. When they uphold dignity, society follows. When they abandon it, the consequences ripple outward to the last man.

At this juncture, there is an opportunity for all stakeholders – across party lines – to pause and reflect. Reaffirming norms of respectful discourse, setting internal standards for communication, and prioritising public interest over momentary applause can help restore balance. Media needs to play a crucial role by not promoting or repeating sensational utterances for increasing their viewership.

For the next generation

Democracy thrives not merely on the freedom of speech, but on the wisdom with which that freedom is exercised. The younger generation, the future of the country, must be inspired by principled political discourse. When leaders speak with integrity and purpose, they not only shape public opinion and culture but also motivate young citizens to strive for excellence and grow into worthy contributors to the nation.

The need of the hour therefore is, not louder voices, but moderated ones – grounded in dignity, guided by responsibility, and committed to the larger good.

The author is a former IAS officer of the Tamil Nadu cadre.

Over 70% of police back immunity for using force

Official data on injuries sustained during police operations contradict numbers presented in news coverage and reports

DATA POINT

Devanshi Bihani
Nitika Francis
Gandla Sneha

The police response to the Cockerroach Janta Party's (CJP) "Chalo Sansad" march earlier this week has once again put the spotlight on the powers of the police. As videos showing tear gas, pellet guns, and lathi charges circulated widely, questions resurfaced over when force may be used, the safeguards governing arrests, and the balance between maintaining public order and exercising civil liberties. Under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), force may be used to disperse an unlawful assembly only after an order to disperse is disobeyed, while the National Human Rights Commission's Manual on Human Rights for Police Officers requires officers to rely on persuasion, advice and warning, using only minimum force when force becomes unavoidable. Yet the Status of Policing in India Report 2025, which surveyed 8,276 police personnel across 17 States and UTs, suggests that many in the police favour broader coercive powers.

One of the most striking findings was that more than 70% of respondents agreed that police should be allowed to use force without fear of punishment in order to properly discharge their responsibilities (Chart 1). Nearly as many (69%) believed that the police should be allowed to arrest and detain suspected criminals without any court investigation, revealing a tendency to exercise power arbitrarily (Chart 2).

Further, more than half of the respondents (55%) considered it either "very" or "somewhat" important for the police to use "tough methods" to create fear among the public (Chart 3). Around two-thirds said that public pressure influences the police to

deal with suspected criminals with a "heavy hand". Nearly half of the respondents (48%) said that more preventive arrests of "anti-social elements" would be very useful in reducing crime (Table 1).

The survey's findings also raise questions about the perceptions of due process after arrest. Only 41% of police personnel said that statutory arrest procedures are always followed. These include informing the arrested person of the grounds of arrest, preparing arrest and inspection memos, notifying family members, ensuring a medical examination, and informing the accused of the right to contact a lawyer. One in five believed private consultation of the arrested with their lawyers should never be permitted. These findings offer a glimpse into institutional attitudes, their misalignment with legal frameworks, and the need for sensitising police on use of force.

The report notes that "India's otherwise robust crime data begins to waver when it comes to incidents of torture or deaths in custody" and that the available data is "inaccurate and inconsistent". The past few editions of the National Crime Record Bureau's (NCRB) 'Crime in India' report have shown a declining number of civilians injured during police operations despite the occurrence of many widely reported incidents.

For instance, the NCRB says only 76 civilians were injured during police operations in India in 2020 despite the beginning of the year witnessing widespread protests against the Citizenship Amendment Act, particularly in north-east Delhi. A report by the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights states that over 200 were injured in Delhi alone. Another case of under-reporting was in 2024, when only two civilians were injured during police operations, as per the NCRB. The 'Dilli Chalo' protests organised by farmers in that year resulted in police resorting to using force on many occasions (Chart 4).



Chart 1: "To properly fulfil their responsibilities, police should be allowed to use force without any fear of punishment" (Values in %)

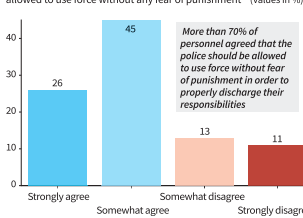


Chart 3: The importance of using tough methods to create fear (Values in %)

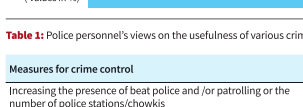


Table 1: Police personnel's views on the usefulness of various crime-control measures (Values in %)

Measures for crime control	Very useful	Somewhat useful	Not much useful	Not at all useful
Increasing the presence of beat police and/or patrolling or the number of police stations/chowkis	64	25	7	2
Recruiting more women into the police	58	26	10	5
More preventive arrests of "anti-social elements"	48	36	10	5
Forming special squads that can detain people indefinitely	43	28	15	12

Chart 4: Civilians injured during riots due to police firing and lathi charge in India as per NCRB

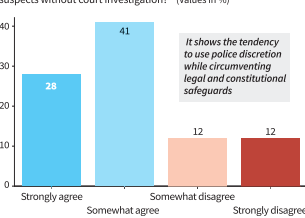


The police beat

The Status of Policing in India 2025 report offers glimpses into the institutional attitude of the police in the country and the need for reforms. The charts below show the responses of the police personnel surveyed for the report for the questions mentioned in the respective charts

Brutality of power: Police personnel carry out a lathi charge on protesters during the "Chalo Sansad" march from Jantar Mantar to Parliament against the NEET paper leak, in New Delhi on July 20.

Chart 2: "Should the police be allowed to arrest and detain suspects without court investigation?" (Values in %)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The King comes to the park

FIFTY YEARS AGO JULY 29, 1976

The King comes to the park

Madras, July 28: The Madras Snake Park, Guindy, has a new addition – a King Cobra. It was caught in the North Andaman rain forest on June 15 by Mr. Romulus Whitaker, Honorary Director of the Park. Since coming to Madras on July 1, it has been housed in a special enclosure, where its natural habitat is simulated.

A King Cobra brought to the Snake Park from Thailand died after seven months. Another from Karnataka also did not survive for long. Hence efforts are being made to air condition the enclosure. Visitors can see it moving in the cooler hours of the day.

According to Mr. Whitaker, the King Cobra is found only in certain rain forests and in extreme estuarine mangrove swarms of the Sunderbans (Bengal), the Bhitarkanika sanctuary on the Orissa coast, and the Western Ghats.

Twelve to 15 inches long when hatched, King cobras can grow to a maximum length of 19 feet, with a girth of about five inches. The female lays about 20 eggs at a time, and the hatching takes about two months. (The snake brought to Madras is a female).

The King Cobra is not a true cobra, though it is also poisonous. It is not of the same genus as the common cobra.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JULY 29, 1926

The Czar's fortune

A special cable to "The Times of India" from London, dated July 26th states:—

A former attaché at the Czar's court informs certain Italian newspapers that Czar Nicholas deposited a fortune in London on the outbreak of war of which, despite withdrawals to alleviate Russian distress, £12,000,000 plus interest remains.

The Czar's surviving relatives desire King George or ex-King Manuel to arbitrate its disposal but cannot legally prove the Czar is dead.

"The Daily News" says inquiries in Russian and British Diplomatic circles do not confirm or deny the report. Although the sum may be exaggerated it must be remembered that the Kaiser before abdication saved half a million sterling yearly. The Soviet Embassy is sceptical. They admit large sums of Czarist money exist in London. General Koltchak sent to London £3,000,000 of Russian State funds when he captured Kazan.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of e-Zero FIRs registered in Delhi since May 2025

6,115 Delhi has recorded the highest number of e-Zero FIRs among the 18 States and Union territories that have implemented the system for cyber financial fraud cases, the government informed Parliament on Tuesday. Delhi registered 6,115 e-Zero FIRs since implementing the system in May 2025. PTI

Cumulative cost overrun registered by infrastructure projects

4.92 in ₹ lakh crore. Infrastructure projects worth above ₹150 crore each registered a cumulative cost overrun of around ₹4,92,752 crore, as per a govt. report for June 2026. A total of 1,847 ongoing projects were monitored and it was found that the total revised cost was ₹40,54,473 crore compared to their original cost of ₹35,61,721 crore. PTI

Number of Meghalaya voters marked under ASDD category

1.5 lakh. Nearly 1.5 lakh electors in Meghalaya have been marked under the absent, shifted, dead and duplicate (ASDD) category during the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, the Chief Electoral Officer B.D.R. Tiwari's office said on Tuesday. A total of 1,49,656 electors, (6.37% of the State's electorate) fall under this category. PTI

Minimum balance penalties collected by private sector banks

4,949 in ₹ crore. Private sector banks have collected ₹4,948.71 crore from account holders for failing to maintain minimum average balance in their current accounts and savings accounts in FY26, Parliament was informed on Tuesday. During the period under review, public sector banks collected ₹2,137.92 crore for the same. PTI

Number of Ayushman cards generated under the AB-PMJAY

44.73 crore. More than 44.73 crore Ayushman cards have been created under the Ayushman Bharat-Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB-PMJAY), while over 12.69 crore hospital admissions worth ₹1.92 lakh crore have been authorised under the scheme, the Parliament was told on Tuesday. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Curbs on panchayat powers in Bengal

The Suwendu Adhikari govt. recently removed panchayat pradhans' powers to issue birth and death certificates. It also passed a law transferring financial disbursement rights from elected gram pradhans to panchayat secretaries and other officials. The moves signal increasing bureaucratic involvement in local self-governance.

EXPLAINER

Shiv Sahay Singh

In the last week of July 2026, the Bharatiya Janata Party government in West Bengal stripped the elected heads of panchayats of administrative and financial powers. On July 23, 2026, a State government notification stated that gram panchayat pradhans and municipal chairpersons will transition out of their previous roles as registrars regarding birth and death registrations. The Suwendu Adhikari government said that dedicated government officers would be appointed as registrars for every gram panchayat and municipality to streamline record-keeping of birth and death certificates and administrative workflows.

The very day the notification was issued, the State's Chief Secretary, Manoj Agarwal, held a press conference stating that there were irregularities in the issuance of birth certificates during the special intensive revision (SIR). The police held raids at several municipalities and civic bodies, where it seized birth and death records.

The State government argued that the move was aimed to ensure transparency in public service and curb corruption in the issuance of birth and death certificates. Birth and death certificates have been a contentious issue, particularly after an SIR, which removed about 12% of voters in West Bengal. Since the newly elected government has made it a priority to identify and deport illegal immigrants from Bangladesh, having officials oversee birth and death certificates appeals to the State government more than leaving the responsibility with elected representatives.

Deprived of financial powers

The West Bengal Legislative Assembly on Saturday passed the West Bengal Panchayat (Second Amendment), 2026 Bill, depriving elected representatives of



Bengal's BJP govt. stripped the elected panchayat heads of administrative and financial powers. PTI

panchayats of financial powers.

The legislation seeks to amend several provisions of the West Bengal Panchayat Act, 1973, with Section 6 transferring cheque-signing and financial disbursement rights from elected gram pradhans to panchayat secretaries, executive assistants, and block development officers. The statement of objects and reasons of the Bill said that the legislation was brought to ensure stability of panchayat bodies for the time-bound delivery of services.

Participating in the discussion on the bill, Panchayat Affairs and Rural Development Minister Dilip Ghosh said that the legislation does not intend to curtail the constitutional powers of elected panchayat heads. "Rather, it is aiming at curtailing the authority for corruption and commission against rural civic services. Henceforth, the elected panchayat heads will only approve any proposal. But the bill (financial bills/cheques) will be cleared and sanctioned by the bureaucrats," he said.

The Minister alleged that in many instances, pradhans have refused to sign work-related documents due to issues regarding alleged "cut money" (kickbacks).

He stated that the objective of the amendment is to curb such irregularities. Mr. Ghosh claimed that among all States in the country, it is only in West Bengal that panchayat pradhans possess such financial powers, and that economic interests have been a major factor behind the violence witnessed during panchayat elections.

Historical significance

West Bengal was among the first States in the country to implement a three-tier panchayat system. Almost two decades before the 73rd Constitutional Amendment of 1993, which officially gave constitutional status to the panchayati raj system in rural India, establishing a uniform three-tier local government structure, West Bengal had in 1973 passed a panchayat act, and the first panchayat elections were held in June 1978. With welfare schemes delivered at the panchayat level, gram panchayat members and pradhans gained enormous power. The control over local panchayats meant control over resources of the State.

With panchayats playing a crucial role in the delivery of public services, corruption and violence slowly crept in.

The last panchayat elections in West Bengal, held in 2023, witnessed widespread violence, with inter-party and intra-party clashes resulting in over 50 deaths. The previous elections during the Trinamool Congress and Left Front regimes also witnessed large-scale violence. The control over local resources and area domination by holding power in panchayats had become a hallmark of rural societies in West Bengal.

The fall of the Trinamool regime had brought to the fore widespread corruption at the panchayat level. The gram pradhan and elected panchayat representatives used to charge kickbacks for the delivery of services. The widespread public anger against the pradhans and elected members of panchayats after the change in the regime reflected the corruption in the system.

The politics behind powers being curtailed

After the BJP victory in the Assembly polls, the space occupied by the Opposition, particularly the Trinamool, has crumbled. Twenty of the 28 MPs have joined the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI), and 65 of the 80 MLAs have split, claiming to be the real Trinamool Congress. What has largely remained untouched by the defections is the three-tier panchayat system in the State, comprising 3,317 gram panchayats with 63,000 elected members, 341 panchayat samitis with over 9700 elected members, and about 20 zilla parishads with 970 members. Almost 90% of the elected representatives at the three-tier panchayats are from the Trinamool. A significant majority of them have stopped performing their responsibilities, fearing public anger and the possibility of being booked in corruption cases.

The next panchayat election will be held in 2028. Therefore, the BJP government has decided to allocate administrative and financial powers to officials instead of elected gram panchayat heads, a move that will increase bureaucratic intervention in local self-governance.

THE GIST

West Bengal was among the first States in the country to implement a three-tier panchayat system. With welfare schemes delivered at the panchayat level, gram panchayat members and pradhans gained enormous power.

A provision of the West Bengal Panchayat (Second Amendment), 2026 Bill seeks to transfer financial disbursement rights to panchayat secretaries, executive assistants, and block development officers.

Will the govt. relax rules on airport-airline ownership?

Has the Adani Group's MoU with Embraer prompted the Centre's rethink on cross-ownership rules?

Jagriti Chandra

The story so far:

Following a request from the Adani Group, the Ministry of Civil Aviation is examining whether to relax cross-ownership restrictions between airport operators and airlines. Officials are preparing a concept note for consultations with the NITI Aayog and other government ministries before any proposal is taken to the Union Cabinet.

What is the government proposing?

The restrictions under review are embedded in airport concession agreements rather than in legislation. The concession agreements for Delhi and Mumbai airports cap aggregate airline ownership in the airport operator at 10%, while those for the Noida International Airport (Jewar) and Navi Mumbai airports

allow up to 26% ownership in an airline. These provisions can also be applied in reverse, effectively restricting airport operators such as Adani from acquiring significant stakes in airlines.

While the Adani Group denied media reports and said it had no interest in entering the airline business, a separate report cited a letter from Adani Airports CEO Arun Bansal stating that Adani Defence and Aerospace "was evaluating participating in the airline business to play a meaningful role in bridging connectivity in tier-2 and tier-3 cities". Government officials have latched on to this rationale, arguing that amending the cross-ownership rules would enable new airline entrants and help break the near-duopoly of IndiGo and the Air India group in the domestic market.

The interest comes at a time when the Adani Group has signed an MoU with Brazilian aircraft manufacturer Embraer

to explore local production of passenger aircraft. Embraer has said that setting up a final assembly line (FAL) in India would depend on securing a substantial aircraft order from the country.

How will concerns be addressed?

The current concession agreements maintain a separation between airport operators and airlines to prevent potential conflicts of interest by ensuring airports remain neutral infrastructure providers and do not favour affiliated carriers in gate allocation, terminal access, airport facilities or other operational decisions.

Government officials say any relaxation of the rules is likely to be accompanied by safeguards to ensure an "arm's length" relationship between airport and airline businesses. Among the measures under consideration are provisions preventing the direct or indirect sharing of commercially sensitive information,

including data relating to slot allocation and airport operations. The proposal is also expected to prohibit common key managerial personnel from holding executive positions in both the airport and airline entities.

The Adani Group is already the largest airport operator in the country with 8 airports in its kitty. It also has a 99.98% stake in maintenance, repair and overhaul company Airworks, has an agreement to acquire a 72.8% stake in pilot training organisation Flight Simulation Technique Centre, ground handling, retail and food and beverage concessions at airports.

How have airlines reacted?

India's two largest airline groups — IndiGo and Air India — have opposed the reported move, arguing that allowing airport operators to own airlines would create conflicts of interest and weaken competition.

IndiGo Managing Director Rahul Bhatia said there was "no global precedent because it would typically raise a massive conflict of interest, and over a period of time it would go against the interest of consumers."

Air India has expressed similar reservations. A senior executive told *The Hindu* that "vertical consolidation" in aviation is problematic, pointing to the Adani Group's presence across multiple segments of the aviation value chain.

According to the executive, ownership across so many parts of the ecosystem could disadvantage competing airlines and ultimately reduce competition and employment in the sector.

What are some global examples of such cross ownership?

While common ownership between airports and airlines exists in jurisdictions such as Singapore, Qatar and the UAE, these examples largely involve government ownership of both entities.

In Singapore, both Changi Airport Group and Singapore Airlines are ultimately owned by the government, with Temasek Holdings holding a majority stake in Singapore Airlines, while Qatar owns both Hamad International Airport and Qatar Airways, and the government of Dubai owns Dubai Airports and Emirates.

These examples differ from India in that each has one dominant state-backed flag carrier that anchors the hub airport, rather than multiple privately owned domestic carriers competing at privately operated airports. India's proposal, by contrast, would permit common ownership in a competitive market with multiple privately owned airlines, raising concerns over potential conflicts of interest and whether airport operators could accord preferential treatment to affiliated carriers.

KEYWORD

Beyond national interest: role of ethics and emotions in world politics

History offers numerous examples of ethics shaping international politics. Foreign policy is not merely an exercise in strategic calculation; it is also shaped by moral perceptions and collective emotions, as illustrated by the change in public perception towards the Israel-Palestine conflict.

Dhananjay Tripathi

The language of world politics has become remarkably predictable. Every military strike, diplomatic initiative, economic sanction, or strategic partnership is justified in the name of national interest. Television debates and commentaries have a common vocabulary – power, deterrence, balance of power, strategic autonomy, and security. It almost appears as though International Relations has become an emotionless discipline, focused on power concentration, where morality and ethics have little place. Yet the defining geopolitical crises of recent years tell a very different story.

Influence of Western traditions
International Relations, both as an academic discipline and as a practice of diplomacy, has been largely shaped by Western intellectual traditions, with much of academic research originating in the United States of America. No wonder, famous IR scholar, Stanley Hoffman, in his article, argued that IR is an American Social Science. It is difficult to refute Hoffman's argument because initially the modern international order emerged when European powers dominated much of the world, leaving the Global South with little role in designing the institutions, norms, and rules that continue to govern global politics. However, the discipline itself acquired its modern identity after the Second World War, with the U.S.-based scholar, Hans Morgenthau's Realism becoming the dominant framework for understanding international affairs. Realism portrays the international system as anarchic and argues that states, in the absence of a central authority, are compelled to pursue their national interests. Although the theory is far more nuanced than its popular interpretation suggests, public discourse has reduced it to two defining ideas—anarchy and national interest. Over time, Realism travelled from classrooms to newsrooms, becoming the default language through which foreign policy is interpreted.

There is much to appreciate in the Realist tradition. It reminds us that power, military capability, and strategic calculations remain central to international politics. However, the dominance of Realism has also encouraged the belief that foreign policy is little more than a rational pursuit of national interest. Ethical considerations are often dismissed as idealistic, while emotions are treated as irrational distractions. Yet certain recent scholarships in International Relations have increasingly challenged this assumption. Scholars such as Neta Crawford have argued that emotions are not the opposite of rationality; rather, they are integral to political judgment. Fear, grief, anger, humiliation, empathy, and pride actively shape how leaders interpret threats, define interests, and respond to crises. Foreign policy, therefore, is not merely an exercise in cold strategic calculation, but also a product of moral perceptions and collective emotions. This dynamic is encapsulated by scholar Brent Sasley, who notes that while state leaders make



Moral reckoning: A protest held in solidarity with Palestine, condemning Israel's actions against Gaza, in Bengaluru on September 26, 2025. ALLEN EGENUSE J.

formal decisions as members of a group, "they do so within a particular (social) context and on that (social) basis".

Question of political legitimacy

The recent U.S.-Iran conflict illustrates this point. Much of the strategic analysis focused on military capabilities, damage assessments, and the future balance of power in West Asia. Comparatively little attention was paid to the emotional and ethical consequences of the conflict. The assassination of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was not only Iran's Supreme Leader but also one of the most influential religious figures in the Shia world, produced consequences that extended far beyond military calculations. Rather than weakening the Iranian state, his death generated an extraordinary wave of national solidarity. A society that had appeared politically divided only months earlier united around a shared sense of loss, nationalism, and religious identity. Crawford's observation that grief and the desire for revenge continue to shape political behaviour long after the battlefield has fallen silent is particularly relevant in this context. Military planners may calculate strategic gains, but societies often respond through memory, identity, and emotion. Therefore, it is important to note that foreign policy must not be judged solely by the actions of a government, but also by how those actions shape and influence global public opinion. The debate surrounding the assassination largely focused on how Washington would engage with a post-Khamenei Iran. Far less attention was paid to the ethical questions raised by such an operation and its implications for America's moral standing.

The changing international perception of Israel offers another important example. Following the Hamas attacks of October 2023, Israel received widespread sympathy and support across much of the world. Most governments affirmed Israel's right to defend itself. However, as the humanitarian crisis in Gaza deepened, due to mindless aggression shown by the

Israeli army, public opinion began to shift. Large demonstrations across Europe and North America reflected growing concerns over civilian suffering and questioned the proportionality of Israel's military response. In this, governments and societies increasingly spoke in different voices. While many governments continued to emphasise security considerations, public opinion became increasingly influenced by humanitarian concerns. Thus, while military superiority can alter realities on the battlefield, it cannot prevent the erosion of moral legitimacy.

Ethical concerns over globalisation

History offers numerous examples of ethics shaping international politics. Throughout the Cold War, the U.S. consistently presented itself as the defender of democracy, human rights, and individual liberty while portraying Soviet communism as an authoritarian system hostile to political freedom. The post-war liberal international order derived much of its legitimacy not merely from military and economic strength but also from its claim to uphold universal values. Even globalisation was promoted as a project that would bring societies closer together through greater interdependence and cooperation. Although globalisation generated unprecedented economic growth, it failed to bridge the structural inequalities between the Global North and the Global South, leading many to question whether the liberal international order had fulfilled its ethical promises.

The position of Global South

Historically, the Global South has been among the most vocal in injecting moral considerations into international politics. The Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) was not merely a strategy to avoid Cold War rivalries; it represented a normative vision of sovereign equality and a collective call for a more just world order. Contemporary India continues to invoke similar ideas through its emphasis on the Global South and the civilisational

philosophy of '*Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*'—the world is one family. Notably, India's international standing has historically rested not only on its growing economic and strategic capabilities but also on its democratic institutions, pluralism, and anti-colonial legacy. During the Bangladesh Liberation War of 1971, for instance, international public opinion gradually shifted in India's favour after the humanitarian catastrophe in East Pakistan became widely known. More recently, India's consistent opposition to cross-border terrorism has enjoyed broad international support because it resonates with widely accepted ethical norms.

This moral capital, however, cannot be taken for granted; it must be continuously reinforced through consistent foreign policy choices. For instance, India's relatively restrained response to recent developments in West Asia has generated debate over whether its pursuit of strategic autonomy truly aligns with the ethical principles it frequently projects. Ultimately, India's international standing is built on more than just its market size. It is widely applauded as a vibrant, multicultural nation where democracy has successfully endured.

In conclusion, it is a mistake to interpret International Relations merely as the study of the redistribution of power; it is equally crucial to understand how that power is evaluated. In a world defined by Artificial Intelligence, digital media, transnational activism, and instantaneous communication, wars are no longer judged solely by governments or strategic analysts. Instead, real-time images of civilian suffering, humanitarian crises, and political violence actively shape international narratives as they unfold. While Realism remains highly relevant for explaining why states pursue power and security, achieving a comprehensive and nuanced understanding of world politics requires us to examine how societies accept, reject, or morally evaluate that power. (Dhananjay Tripathi teaches International Relations at the South Asian University, New Delhi.)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning and the origin of the idiom "grinning like a Cheshire cat"? (D. Geetham, Madurai)
When you say that someone is "grinning like a Cheshire cat", it means that he/she has a broad smile on his/her face. Here are a few examples:

Divya obviously knows something. She has been walking around all morning grinning like a Cheshire cat.

When Leya walked in grinning like a Cheshire cat, I knew that she had come first in her class.

Cheshire is the name of a county in England. Before you jump to any conclusions, let me assure you that the cats from this county aren't famous for their grins! The place, however, was famous for its cheese.

The cheese makers from this place used to draw the figure of a smiling cat on a special type of cheese. People who bought this type of cheese saw the face of a cat with a broad smile.

So the cat in the idiom "grin like a Cheshire cat" is not a real cat, but the figure that was found on cheese. Although the idiom has been around for several centuries, it was the author of 'Alice in Wonderland', Lewis Carroll, who made it famous.

In the novel, Alice runs into a large cat with a big smile. When Alice asks why he is grinning, the Duchess replies, "It's a Cheshire cat and that's why." In the story, the cat begins to disappear slowly; it is the tail that disappears first and the smile fades last.

So at one point all that Alice sees is the face with a big smile.

What is the meaning of "Gandhi's revenge"? (P. Balasubramanian, Chennai)

Ever heard the expression "Montezuma's revenge"? It means diarrhoea. Tourists who went to Mexico invariably ended up with an upset stomach – they attributed this to the spicy food and also the water.

Example:

Satish had a little touch of Montezuma's revenge on the second day. You can now probably guess what "Gandhi's revenge" means. It's an attack of dysentery that some people experience after eating spicy Indian food. Of course, one doesn't have to visit India to experience "Gandhi's revenge"; you can suffer the consequences after eating in any of the restaurants abroad.

My friend claims that the word "latrinoqram" exists. Is it true? (P. Harish, Hyderabad)

We have all come across the words "telegram", "phonogram". But "latrinoqram"? Sounds ridiculous, doesn't it? But your friend is right, the word "latrinoqram" does exist.

As you have probably guessed, it consists of two words – "latrine" and "gram".

A "phonogram" is a message that you receive over the phone. So, what do you think a "latrinoqram" is? Yes, it's a message that you receive in the latrine! In this case, it is a rumour which originates in the latrines of offices – working people have a tendency to exchange a lot of information (gossip) in bathrooms.

Examples:

There was a latrinoqram yesterday about the boss being asked to resign.

Sudha is marrying Sudhir! No way! That's just another latrinoqram.

Published in *The Hindu* on June 5, 2001

THE DAILY QUIZ

Some significant events occurred on July 29. Here is a quiz on observances, birthdays and everything else that happened on this day

K. Abhinava

QUESTION 1

This U.S. President signed a legislation to create NASA after the Soviet Union launched Sputnik 1. Name the President and the year when the legislation was created.

QUESTION 2

This Swedish Economist, who was born on this day, received the Nobel Peace Prize in 1961. He also served as the secretary-general of the UN. Identify the economist.

QUESTION 3

At an international summit

held in 2010 it was decided that July 29 would be marked as International Tiger Day. Did India take part in the Summit and name the host country.

QUESTION 4

The first part of this three-part fantasy novel series was published on this day in 1954. The series was first revised and republished in 1965. Identify the title of the first book.

QUESTION 5

The wedding of this royal couple on this day was watched by over 700 million people on television. It was broadcast in 74 countries. Identify the couple.



Visual question: A part of the wreckage of the Malaysian Airlines flight MH370 was found on the shore of Réunion Island in the Indian Ocean on July 29, 2015. What is the part called? AFP

Questions and answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. Three properties from India were the first to be given UNESCO World Heritage Site status in 1983. **Ans: Ajanta Caves, Ellora Caves, the Agra Fort**
2. Unique feature of the Khangchendzonga National Park inscribed to the list. **Ans: It is the only one in the Mixed category**
3. The inscribed property across Tamil Nadu, West Bengal and Himachal Pradesh. **Ans: The Mountain Railways of India (Nilgiri Mountain Railway, Darjeeling Himalayan Railway and Kalka Shimla Railway)**
4. Name the two sites that were at different times part of 'World Heritage in Danger' list. **Ans: Manas Wildlife Sanctuary and the Monuments at Hampi**
5. This site is transnational being shared with six other countries. **Ans: The Architectural Work of Le Corbusier**
6. Inscribed in 2003, this site exhibits the earliest traces of human life in India. **Ans: Rock Shelters of Bhimbetka, Madhya Pradesh**
7. The Indian currency notes featuring the Konark Sun Temple and the Sanchi Stupa. **Ans: Rs. 10 and Rs. 200 respectively**
Visual: Name this WHS and the State in which it is located. **Ans: Rani ki Vav, Gujarat**
Correction: In Question 2 of the quiz featured yesterday, the year should have been 2016 and not 2014 as published. The error is regretted.
Early birds: Prem Nath Tiwari| Tamal Biswas| Sunil Madhavan| Sudhir Thapa | Sitaram Saharay

Word of the day

Laconic:

through the use of as few words as possible

Synonyms: terse, succinct, concise

Usage: The Minister remained laconic despite persistent queries from reporters.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/laconic

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ləˈkɒnɪk/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Text & Context'

From Page One

Release all minors held over student protests: SC

The Bench, including Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V. Mohana, issued notices to the Union government, the Delhi government and the Chief Secretaries of Maharashtra, Bihar, Assam, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, West Bengal and Kerala, directing them to place their responses on record. It indicated that it would decide whether to order an independent probe after considering the responses filed by the authorities.

"The allegations made by the petitioners, prima facie, establish a compelling case for an independent and impartial investigation into the incidents of violence," the Bench observed, adding that the proposed probe would also examine complaints by the families of police personnel who were allegedly injured during the protests.

The interim directions came while the top court was hearing a batch of petitions alleging the use of disproportionate force by the police against protesters during demonstrations over the NEET examination paper leaks.

Taking note of petitions alleging that student protesters had been illegally arrested and detained by the police, the top court directed the authorities to forthwith release all minors detained in connection with the demonstrations. It clarified that, where required, they may be released on the "execution of a simple bond by themselves or their family members", if such a requirement was insisted upon for furnishing surety. While permitting the police to continue investigating the FIRs registered in relation to the protests, it restrained the authorities from taking any coercive action against students unless they had criminal antecedents.

As an interim measure, the Bench directed the police authorities to preserve all CCTV footage, drone recordings, body-worn camera footage, wireless communication records and PCR call records relating to the protests.

Industrial growth hits 23-month high of 7.3%

"The sharp uptick reflects broad-based strength in industrial activity, supported by improving manufacturing output, resilient domestic demand, and sustained momentum in investment-led sectors," Shashwat Singh, Fundamental Analyst at Bajaj Broking said.

The heatwave in several parts of the country in June drove growth in the electricity and gas supply sector to a 25-month high of 10.6%, up from 9.9% in May. Some part of this strong growth could also have been due to a base effect since the sector had contracted 2% in June last year.

The capital goods sector also saw growth accelerating to a relatively robust 14.2% in June 2026, up from 3.45% in June last year. However, analysts say that despite this strong growth, the outlook for the months ahead is not as positive.

"While this reflects steady capital expenditure execution, our forward-looking credit outlook adopts a cautious stance," Vikrant Chaturvedi, Associate Director at Brickwork Ratings said. "The 9.3% growth in intermediate goods supports near-term supply chain stability, yet the broader macroeconomic landscape is clouded by significant risks."

The data also showed that consumer demand seems to be recovering, with growth in both consumer durables and non-durables accelerating in June. The consumer durables category grew 7.7% in June 2026, the fastest since November 2025, while the consumer non-durables sector grew 4.9%, the fastest in the same period of time.

India's Gen Z wants Pak. to end terror activities: govt.

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

India on Tuesday reiterated that Pakistan continues to promote cross-border terrorism as a state policy, with the External Affairs Ministry saying Pakistan's Gen Z should "take note" that people of India, including the Indian Gen Z, are aware of Islamabad's support for terrorism against India.

"Pakistan has been sponsoring cross-border terrorism against India for decades. The people of India, including Gen Z, have been demanding that the Pakistani state-sponsored terrorism must come to an end. We hope their counterparts are taking due note," Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said, regarding the online support extended by the Pakistani social media handlers to student protesters at Jantar Mantar.

CBI files chargesheet against 13 accused in NEET paper leak case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has filed a chargesheet against 13 arrested accused persons in the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak case, said the agency on Tuesday. All of them are currently in judicial custody.

The chargesheet comes days after BJP MP Dharmendra Pradhan resigned as Union Education Minister on July 25, in the wake of over a month-long agitation led by the Cockerroach Janta Party.

The agency has invoked provisions related to criminal conspiracy, cheating, criminal breach of trust, destruction of evidence and other associated charges under the Prevention of Corruption Act, and the Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act.

It has cited 360 witness

RAF diary entry shows Delhi Police authorised pellet gun use on July 20

RAF registered entry at Parliament Street police station on July 22, soon after *The Hindu's* report on pellet gun injuries: RAF later withdrew pump action guns, electric shields, anti-riot guns, shock batons from personnel deployed at Jantar Mantar

Vijata Singh
NEW DELHI

Days after the Delhi Police denied the usage of pellet guns during the July 20 march to Parliament — in which at least four persons reported being hit with pellets — a general diary entry filed at Parliament Street police station reveals that the Rapid Action Force (RAF) did fire two rounds from an anti-riot gun on the directions of a Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP) rank officer.

The *Hindu* has accessed the general diary entry, which was registered by the RAF at 1.24 a.m. on July 22. This was the first time that a pellet gun was used against unarmed protesters in the national capital.

Following the July 20 incident, the RAF withdrew shock batons, electric shields, pump-action guns, and the anti-riot guns, which fire pellets, from personnel deployed at Jantar Mantar. A review by an RAF Inspector-General also highlighted "serious deficiencies" in RAF beha-

viour during the march, in violation of its principle of "sensitive policing".



RAF personnel deployed near the Parliament House during the CJP protest march in New Delhi on July 20. SHV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

viour during the march, in violation of its principle of "sensitive policing".

Two rounds fired

The diary entry says that, to control the crowd during the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP) protest, "on the orders of Zone-1, DCP, Jantar Mantar," the RAF Deputy Commandant fired "55 rounds of non-electrical shell, 15 rounds of electrical shell, five tear smoke grenade, two rounds using ballistic cartridges with plastic pellets from an anti-

riot gun." The RAF, which is the anti-riot unit of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), was deployed and was under the operational control of the Delhi Police at the time of the incident.

The diary entry was made hours after *The Hindu* reported on July 21 that two people allegedly hit by pellets fired by RAF personnel had undergone surgery at government hospitals. One of them, Sahil Lochab, 19, risks losing vision in his right eye due to

a pellet piercing his pupil, his family said.

Police sources said that during a law-and-order situation, Central forces, in this case the RAF, are given a general consent by the police officer concerned, to use all crowd-control equipment at their disposal.

'Serious deficiencies'

Significantly, in a video conference with RAF personnel after the incident, RAF Inspector-General Seema Dhundhia "gave clear directions that during the current Delhi deployment, the situation has been analysed and until further orders pump action guns (PAG), anti-riot Gun (ARG), electric shock weapon, and electric shield shall not be used or issued to personnel."

The minutes of the meeting accessed by *The Hindu* said that "serious deficiencies were observed in many aspects of the operation, which need to be improved in the future."

The Inspector-General reiterated that the core principle of the RAF is

"sensitive policing", and directed that the use of force in every situation must be done only to the necessary extent, in a judicious, fair, restrained, and sensitive manner.

Ms. Dhundhia said that "some videos available on social media showed incidents of RAF personnel using unnecessary force on persons who had already separated from the crowd, deliberately making people fall, and assaulting persons going out of the barricade. Such incidents are completely contrary to the established work culture and image of RAF and are not justified under any circumstances."

Retired Intelligence Bureau Special Director Yashovardhan Azad moved the Supreme Court for a ban on pellet guns on July 27, along with two victims of pellet gun injuries, an artist and another professional. They demanded the decommissioning or ban on the use of wholly or partly metallic kinetic projectiles or pellets fired from pump action rifles or projectile action guns.

Pleas in SC allege illegal detentions in Delhi, Bihar

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

Several petitions before the Supreme Court have alleged that police authorities in Delhi and Bihar resorted to "illegal and arbitrary detention" of individuals associated with the student protests.

An impleaded application, filed by Junaid Malik, who had volunteered to distribute food and water to protesters at Jantar Mantar, said he and his friend were picked up by Delhi Police personnel late on July 24. The application, filed in the ongoing writ petition by Rajya Sabha member Manoj Jha, said they were blindfolded and detained at an undisclosed location overnight and repeatedly questioned by police officers about the source of funds used to distribute food and water.

Another writ petition filed by a 22-year-old law student from Bihar has alleged that he was picked up by the police while participating in the protests on July 25. Despite the Bihar government's decision not to take any action against protesters, the law student was still in judicial custody, the petition said.

MP moves SC over mass surveillance at protest

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Rajya Sabha MP A.A. Rahim moved the Supreme Court on Tuesday against the deployment of facial recognition technology and allied mass surveillance measures by the Delhi Police against students who participated in the Cockerroach Janta Party-linked protests.

"The petition sought a judicial declaration that such surveillance was unconstitutional. Mr. Rahim, represented by advocate Subhash Chandran, sought directions from the court to forthwith cease and desist from using facial recognition technology and other surveillance measures on peaceful protesters without a valid law.

SC hearing on pleas over NEET protests yet to reveal if police kept Ministry in the loop

NEWS ANALYSIS

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Little has been said in the Supreme Court so far about instructions or consultations between the Delhi Police and the Union Home Ministry as violence unfolded in NEET-UG protests in the national capital on July 20.

The Supreme Court judgment of February 2012 in the *Ramlila Maidan Incident versus Home Secretary* refers to the then Delhi Police Commissioner's affidavit that "as a matter of practice, Delhi Police keep the Ministry of Home Affairs duly informed in such matters".

The judgment said the affidavit had reasoned that



The political executive's role is expected to be a key issue in the ongoing court hearings.

the Ministry "for obvious reasons, is concerned about the preservation of law and order in the capital and carefully monitors all situations dealing with public order and tranquility".

The court had recorded from the affidavit that it was "also clear that he [Police Commissioner] was continuously in touch with the senior functionaries of

the Ministry of Home Affairs", and had kept them clued in on the decisions taken by senior police officers on the ground. Under Article 239AA of the Constitution, the Ministry has control over the Delhi Police.

Akin to Jallianwala Bagh

The stand of the political executive would be a crucial part of the Supreme Court hearings into the NEET-UG protests, especially with one of the petitions claiming that the police action on July 20 against students protesting peacefully was "no less than the atrocities of the Jallianwala Bagh".

The Supreme Court, over the decades, has shown a keen awareness and concern about political influence over the police.

Twenty years ago, a Supreme Court judgment in the *Prakash Singh* case had cautioned against the overwhelming influence of the political executive over the police. The 2006 judgment had been based on a petition arguing that reducing the police to a mere tool in the hands of political masters would result in serious violations of the rights of the people.

The 2006 judgment had referred to a research paper 'Political and Administrative Manipulation of the Police' published in 1979 by Bureau of Police Research and Development, warning that "excessive control of the political executive and its principal advisers over the police has the inherent danger of making the police a tool for subverting the process of

law, promoting the growth of authoritarianism, and shaking the very foundations of democracy". One of the issues mentioned was police conduct in large-scale civil unrest.

The *Prakash Singh* case judgment had elaborated that political influence over the police was a reality by quoting from an April 3 1997 letter of the then Home Minister to State governments.

The Union Home Minister, the judgment said, had exhorted the "great national importance to insulate the police from the growing tendency of partisan or political interference in the discharge of its lawful functions of prevention and control of crime including investigation of cases and maintenance of public order".

Truck full of stones found parked at protest site was in police custody, says report

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A truck loaded with stones that was found parked near Jantar Mantar ahead of the July 20 march to Parliament had been seized by the Delhi Police four days earlier and was in police custody when it appeared at the protest site and later outside the Indian Youth Congress (IYC) office, according to a *Newsland* report published on Tuesday.

The Delhi Police, however, said claims alleging that the truck was deliberately deployed near Jantar Mantar or outside any political party office were "false and misleading".

On July 20, Cockerroach Janta Party founder Abhijeet Dipke had pointed out a truck loaded with stones parked near the protest site and demanded an explanation from the Delhi

Delhi police say any claim that truck was deliberately stationed near Jantar Mantar is false and misleading

Police on how it crossed the police cordon and reached the site. "It could have been used to frame the protesters or incite violence," Mr. Dipke said.

The *Newsland* report stated that the truck was found outside the IYC office on Raisina Road on July 25 and had reportedly been parked there since July 21.

According to the report, the truck loaded with stones was taken into the custody of the Delhi Police after it collided with a van on July 16 at the Firoz Shah Road-Kasturba Gandhi Marg crossing. Both vehicles were brought to the *malkhana* (storage facility)

of the Sansad Marg police station. The report quoted an officer at the Sansad Marg police station as saying that the truck was parked right outside the station until July 20. After a video of it being parked at the protest site went viral, the police took the truck to Bhalwa, emptied it, brought it back and parked it at the same spot again.

The Delhi Police, in a statement said, "The truck was seized on July 16 in connection with FIR No. 65/2026 following a road accident involving the truck and a van... The vehicle was initially parked near the Parliament Street police station for safe custody due to space constraints. Considering the law and order arrangements for the 'Chalo Sansad' march, it was later emptied and shifted to a safer location in the early hours of July 20."

Meta apologises for removing PM's video

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Centre has sought a formal explanation from Meta after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's video was briefly taken down by Facebook owing to what an automated platform alert initially described as a "legal request".

In the video posted on 23 July, Mr. Modi sought to reassure students that his administration was taking firm action on NEET examination paper leaks. A source familiar with the

matter told *The Hindu* that the post had been mistakenly flagged by an automated moderation tool designed to filter AI-generated content. Facebook's parent company is said to have apologised for the error.

"The content was removed in error and has since been restored," a Meta spokesperson said. It is understood that the government has summoned a senior executive from Meta's policy and government relations team to explain the error.



APPEAL
Makizhmathi is 3 years old suffering from Acute Lymphoblastic Leukemia. She needs Chemotherapy and Radiation Therapy at Meenakshi Mission Hospital & Research Centre, Madurai. The total cost of treatment is Rs.2,00,000/- Her father works as a Driver. The family is very poor and cannot afford this huge cost. Please support her for the treatment. Donations sent by ChD/D, favouring Meenakshi Mission Hospital & Research Centre, Madurai will be acknowledged. The donations sent through ChD/D NEFT Transfer & GOOGLE PAY (Canara Bank, Nungambakam Branch, Ac. No. 6151201003310, IFSC No. CIBR0031001) favouring WOMEN'S WELFARE SYNDICATE is exempted under 80G IT. All correspondence is done through WWS, Regd. Public Charitable Trust, Flat No. G/F 1, Corridor Apartments, C-25, N-25, N-26, Poojitha Garden Lane, Chennai-600006, Ph: 844-4217401/ 31523781/ 7339978021, E-mail ID: womenswelfaretrust@gmail.com. Website: www.womenwelfaretrustindia.org.

WWS

Paper leak Bill a milestone, says govt.; Opposition calls it 'cosmetic exercise'

Minister says amendment shows PM's resolve not to compromise the future of children; Congress leader asks why the government is amending a law it had hailed as 'historic' just two years ago; SP member slams the govt. over police action

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Treasury and Opposition benches sparred in the Lok Sabha on Tuesday as the House took up the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, with the Opposition describing it as an "admission of failure".

The Bill seeks to strengthen the 2024 anti-paper leak law with stricter punishment of up to 10-year imprisonment and a fine of up to ₹50 lakh.

Initiating the discussion on the Bill, Union Minister Jitendra Singh said the amendment showed Prime Minister Narendra Modi's resolve not to compromise the future of children. The government described it as a "milestone" legislation in the history of Parliament.

"Incidents of paper leaks have taken place in various States ruled by different parties. The anti-paper leak Bill is a reaffirmation of the government's commitment to safeguard the welfare of



Minister Jitendra Singh speaks in the Lok Sabha during the debate on the Public Examinations Amendment Bill, 2026 on Tuesday. PTI

students and youth. The amendment... (is being) brought to make the law more stringent," Mr. Singh said.

Speedy justice

Mr. Singh said the Bill provided for the establishment of Special Fast Track Courts to deal with offences relating to public examinations.

He said it envisaged completion of investigations within two months and trials within three months from the date of filing of chargesheet. The Bill also empowers the Centre

to refer investigation of offences under the Act to a Special Task Force constituted to protect the integrity of public examinations and said harsher punishments alone would not end the menace without structural reforms in the education system.

The Minister also informed the House that the government had already initiated steps for the establishment of the fast-track courts.

The proposed amendments would reinforce deterrence against organised examination-related crimes and ensure speedy justice, he added.

Initiating the debate for the Opposition, Congress deputy leader Gaurav Gogoi questioned why the go-

vernment was amending a law it had hailed as "historic" just two years ago.

"If that law was so effective, why has the government been forced to bring such major amendments within two years?" Mr. Gogoi asked, calling the Bill a "cosmetic exercise" that reflected the failure of the 2024 law enacted after the earlier NEET-UG controversy.

'Inability exposed'

He argued that the latest paper leak had exposed the government's inability to protect the integrity of public examinations and said harsher punishments alone would not end the menace without structural reforms in the education system.

He also questioned the fate of recommendations by a 2024 committee headed by former ISRO Chairman K. Radhakrishnan and sought details of the 47 officials the government claimed to have removed or transferred from the National Testing Agency (NTA).

"Who are these 47 peo-

ple, when the sanctioned strength of the NTA is 34?" Mr. Gogoi asked. He also questioned why the government had so much faith in the NTA chairman. "Is it because he is associated with a particular Sangh?" he asked.

The Congress leader also alleged that 44 of the 45 accused in the 2024 NEET-UG paper leak case had secured bail.

Samajwadi Party (SP) MP Dimple Yadav lashed out at the government for the police action against protesting students.

Responding to the Opposition, BJP MP Anurag Thakur hit out at Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi for sitting on a dharna outside the Prime Minister's residence, saying Mr. Gandhi did so because students did not ask him to lead the protests.

Calling the amendment "transformative", BJP member Bansuri Swaraj accused the Opposition of "selective outrage", contending that paper leaks had also occurred under the UPA government's tenure.

Priyanka, Venugopal seek accountability for police action on NEET protesters

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal and Wayanad MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on Tuesday demanded accountability for the police action against students protesting the NEET-UG paper leak, accusing the Centre of responding to a democratic movement with force instead of addressing the concerns of aspirants.

Participating in the debate on the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, in the Lok Sabha, Ms. Vadra asked Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah to explain who had authorised the use of force, including pellet guns and assault rifles, against protesting students.

"Were they terrorists?" she asked, saying that every lathi blow had damaged the government's credibility more than it had injured the students. Recalling her visit to Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital, Ms. Vadra said she had met the family of an injured



Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra speaks in Lok Sabha during the debate on the amendment to the anti-paper leak Bill. ANI

student and argued that the country's youth had begun losing faith in a system where dishonesty appeared to matter more than merit. Ms. Vadra alleged that 152 examination papers had leaked over the past decade without a single "paper leak mafia" being punished.

Taking a swipe at the Prime Minister, Ms. Vadra said changing camera angles would not help win over Generation Z. "The Prime Minister needs to change the angle of his heart, not the angle of cameras," she said.

Mr. Venugopal said the attacks on peaceful protesters "must be identified and held accountable".

Beginning his speech by reading out a note left behind by a NEET candidate who died by suicide, Mr. Venugopal said it reflected the immense pressure faced by students.

Citing National Crime Records Bureau data, he said student suicides had risen from 8,068 in 2014 to 14,488 at present. "This is not a statistic but an emergency," he said, adding the issue reflected deeper problems in the country's education system.

He questioned the education model where "coaching has become indispensable, students have to approach courts for justice, protesters face police violence, and degrees no longer guarantee jobs".

Akhilesh says police action at protest akin to Emergency

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav on Tuesday compared the police action against students protesting the NEET-UG question paper leak with the Emergency, and claimed the Narendra Modi government had been forced to bend before an unprecedented student movement.

The resignation of former Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan reflected the pressure generated by the student agitation, Mr. Yadav said, participating in the Lok Sabha debate on the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026.

"By removing one 'Pradhan', you effectively saved the 'Pradhan Mantri', the SP leader said.

The police used "lathis with spikes, and electric batons" against students, he said, describing the scenes in Delhi as reminiscent of the Emergency.

DMK reiterates demand to scrap NEET, accuses Centre of ignoring concerns of T.N.

The Hindu Bureau

NEW DELHI

The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) on Tuesday renewed its demand for scrapping the National Eligibility-Cum-Entrance Test (NEET) in the Lok Sabha, arguing that the proposed amendments to the anti-paper leak law fail to address the "core issue" of the medical entrance examination itself.

During the debate on the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, DMK MP Dayanidhi Maran said Tamil Nadu had consistently opposed NEET since its introduction and accused the Centre of ignoring the State's concerns.

"Enough is enough, ban NEET, abolish NEET. Do not go for 'One India, One Examination'." Our strength comes from our diversity," Mr. Maran said, claiming that 26 students had died by suicide over



DMK MP Dayanidhi Maran speaks in the Lok Sabha during the discussion on the amendment to the anti-paper leak law. PTI

the test in Tamil Nadu.

He claimed NEET disadvantaged first-generation learners and students from State boards while benefiting coaching centres. Citing official figures, he said nearly 22 lakh students appear for NEET every year and around 12 lakh qualify, while there are only about 1.39 lakh undergraduate medical seats.

Questioning the rationale for retaining the examination, Mr. Maran asked whether NEET had improved the quality of doctors, reduced infant mor-

tality, strengthened rural healthcare or addressed the shortage of doctors.

Mr. Maran further alleged that he and NCP (SP) MP Supriya Sule were unable to use WhatsApp broadcast lists for three days because of forwarding restrictions, and criticised what he described as the government's unequal treatment of social media platforms.

"We are not your enemy," Ms. Sule said, urging the government to treat the matter with greater seriousness.

Joshi's appointment is an insult to our students, says Rahul

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi on Tuesday launched a sharp attack on Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the appointment of Pralhad Joshi as Union Education Minister, describing him as a "defender of rapists" and "the most filthy type of man".

His objections were over Mr. Joshi's purported remarks after the release of convicts in the Bilkis Bano gang-rape case in 2022.

Speaking to reporters outside Parliament, Mr. Gandhi questioned Mr. Modi's choice at a time when students across the country were protesting over the NEET paper leak.

Calling Mr. Joshi a "defender of rapists", he said: "That is the most filthy type of man. There can be no filthier man than somebody who says that rapists need protection. That is the Education Minister of India today."

"It's strange. It's a strange reaction from the



Rahul Gandhi

Prime Minister. There are so many people in his Cabinet; he could have chosen anyone. But he chooses a person who protects rapists," Mr. Gandhi added.

In a post on X later, Mr. Gandhi alleged that Mr. Joshi's appointment was "an insult to our education system" and to students, particularly young women.

Earlier, Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra made a controversial remark about Mr. Joshi during the Lok Sabha debate on the anti-paper leak Bill. The comment drew protests from Treasury Bench and was later expunged.

Congress's remarks on Pralhad Joshi are misleading, says BJP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Tuesday termed as "condemnable" and "misleading and unacceptable" the remarks made by Priyanka Gandhi Vadra in the Lok Sabha on the newly appointed Union Education Minister Pralhad Joshi as well as the remarks later made outside the House by the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi.

Ms. Vadra's remarks were subsequently expunged by Speaker Om Birla.

Lok Sabha member and BJP's media cell convener Anil Baluni put out a strong statement on behalf of the party after the remarks were made.

"The misleading remarks made today in the Lok Sabha by Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra regarding Union Education Minister Pralhad Joshi, and the subsequent baseless comments by Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi in support of Pri-

yanka Vadra's statement, are extremely unfortunate and condemnable. In a healthy democracy, such misleading and unwarranted remarks against a Union Minister on the floor of the House cannot be accepted," Mr. Baluni said.

The reference made by Ms. Vadra and Mr. Gandhi to a comment by Mr. Joshi in the said matter was "completely incorrect", the House said.

He said Mr. Joshi had, in fact, not made the remarks pertaining to the case of gang-rape survivor Bilkis Bano. "He had merely commented on the legal process and not on the matter itself," Mr. Baluni added.

"Before making such statements, Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Vadra should have read and understood the facts properly. However, distorting statements for political convenience, misleading the country, and levelling baseless allegations has become a habit of the Congress party," he said in the statement.

'Unwise to link women's quota with delimitation'

Nistula Hebbar
NEW DELHI

Bharat Rashtira Samithi leader K.T. Rama Rao has said that the student protests over the leak of NEET question paper was "unique" and an "inflexion" point in Indian polity and that the delimitation Bill, if it is tabled in Parliament, should ensure that the southern States maintain their level of representation in the Lok Sabha.

Speaking to *The Hindu* during his visit to Delhi, Mr. Rao said the protests were not just about paper leaks but seemed to have channelled a number of frustrations among the people that needed a trigger point. While anti-incumbency had built up, he conceded that the BJP still had time to recover, but that



K.T. Rama Rao

the lessons for the Opposition were just as dire.

"What you effectively saw was the manifestation of a series of events and not just one isolated incident that resulted in this. They (the BJP) still have time to make amends and maybe win the youngsters back. Also the situation clearly shows that it was not the principle Opposition nor the Opposition bloc as such, that could inspire confidence, and it

had to be a students-led, kind of leaderless, rudderless kind of a moment, which just emanated like the Arab Spring had (in 2011). Therefore, it's unique and it certainly is an inflection point in Indian politics. If you ask me, Prime Minister Modi and his government have never looked as vulnerable as they did in the last 15 days," he said.

On delimitation, Mr. Rao said it was "unwise" to intertwine women's reservation and delimitation the way the government had done in April in the Special Session to consider the two Bills. "Women's reservation can be implemented without linking it or without intertwining it with delimitation. So the fundamental point of Government of India try-

ing to fire the delimitation gun, you know, using a women reservation as a shoulder to lean on is wrong, whereas the women's reservation Act has already been passed by Parliament," he said.

"Government of India needs to realise that they are sitting on a powder keg. If they mess with the current ratio, where the southern States as a bloc have 24% representation in Parliament, then most certainly there will be a serious protest erupting in the South," he said.

He suggested his own formula. "Why is delimitation done in the first place? Because you want increased participation, representative democracy, more decentralisation, etc. So the one way to do it, is basically increase the num-

ber of MLA seats. If they can go ahead and increase the number of MLA seats across the country, there's 4,000 plus now. That can be enhanced to 6,000. Nobody has a problem. Because then it's within the geographical confines of one State and when it comes to Parliament, you are not disturbing the status quo. The second formula could be one where you actually sit across a table, come to the consensus on how this 24% of South can be maintained as is, so that there is parity and balance," he said.

"There should not be a penalty for good implementation of population policies, you can't have a noose around our neck, say that this is good for you (southern States), and stifle our voice," he said.

CENTRAL ELECTRICITY REGULATORY COMMISSION
6th, 7th, & 8th Floor, Tower-B, World Trade Centre, Nauroji Nagar, New Delhi-110029

Petition No. 202/TL/2026
NOTICE UNDER CLAUSE (a) OF SUB-SECTION (5) OF SECTION 15 OF THE ELECTRICITY ACT, 2003
 An application under Sections 14, 15 and 79(1)(e) of the Electricity Act, 2003 (the Act) has been made by **Dhule Power Transmission Limited**, Windsor, 1st Floor, Unit No. 101, Kalina, Santacruz (East), Mumbai - 400098, Maharashtra for the grant of a separate RTM Transmission Licence to DPTL for 'Implementation of 1 No. of 220 kV line bay at Dhule PS for RE Interconnection (Appl. 2200001584: Adyant Enersol Private Limited: 94 MW)' under the Regulated Tariff Mechanism (hereinafter referred to as "RTM") mode (hereinafter referred to as "The Project"). The scope of the project for which a transmission licence has been sought is as under:

Sl. No.	Scope of the Transmission Scheme	Item Description	Implementation Timeframe	Implementation Agency
1.	Implementation of 1 No. of 220 kV line bay at Dhule PS for RE Interconnection (Appl. 2200001584: Adyant Enersol Private Limited: 94 MW).	220kV line bay - 1 No. (Sec-I)	18 Months from award to implementing agency	Dhule Power Transmission Limited (subsidiary of IndiGrid 2 Pvt Ltd.)
Total Estimated Cost:			₹ 5.32 Cr. (May 25 Price Level)	

2. The Central Transmission Utility of India Limited, vide its letter dated 10.4.2026, has recommended for the grant of a transmission licence to the applicant to establish the proposed transmission system.

3. Based on the material available on the record, the Commission vide order dated 26.7.2026 in Petition No. 202/TL/2026, has proposed to issue a transmission licence to the applicant for the establishment of the transmission scheme as noted in para 1 above.

4. A copy of the application, along with its annexures and enclosures, made by the applicant for the grant of an inter-State transmission licence to **Dhule Power Transmission Limited**, before the Commission can be accessed at the <https://www.indiagrid.co.in/documents-manager/> or inspected by any person in the Commission's office by following the laid down procedure.

5. Notice is hereby given in pursuance of clause (a) of sub-section (5) of Section 15 of the Act that suggestions or objections, if any, to the Commission's proposal to grant a transmission licence to the applicant, as aforesaid, be sent to the undersigned by **5.8.2026** at the above noted address. The suggestions or objections received after the specified date shall not be considered.

6. The application shall be taken up for the further hearing by the Commission on **6.8.2026**. Any person who files suggestions or objections may in his/her discretion attend the hearing, for which no TADA shall be paid by the Commission.

(Harpreet Singh Pruthi)
Secretary

INBRIEF



Nepal PM Shah invited to visit India, says Ministry

India has 'formally' invited Nepal's new Prime Minister Balendra Shah to visit New Delhi, the External Affairs Ministry said on Tuesday. This official confirmation comes days after sections of Nepal's media reported that Mr. Shah's adviser Kumar Ben visited New Delhi in early July and discussed his visit with National Security Adviser Ajit Doval. Prime Minister Narendra Modi had congratulated the newly elected Prime Minister on social media soon after Mr. Shah swept the polls in March. "We have invited Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah formally," Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said.

HC to hear Gadkari plea on deepfake posts on August 5

The Bombay High Court on Tuesday said it would hear on August 5 Union Minister Nitin Gadkari's plea against Meta, X, Google, and unknown persons over allegedly defamatory deepfake content circulated on social media, falsely linking him to the Centre's Ethanol Blending Programme (EBP). The Bench of Justice Arif Doctor directed the Union Minister's advocate, Sandeep S. Ladda, to serve copies of the civil suit to all respondents and adjourned the matter. Mr. Gadkari has sought damages of ₹1 crore, alleging that the viral content had tarnished his reputation.

13 Indian seafarers trapped in Ukraine port

M. Kalyanaraman
CHENNAI

Fifteen sailors, including 13 Indians, are trapped in a "terrible and life-threatening situation" at the Ukrainian port of Chornomorsk in the Black Sea owing to missile and drone attacks in the vicinity, says Forward Seamen's Union of India (FSUI).

The crew members, who are onboard M.V. AMIRI, are living under the constant fear of a direct hit at any moment, according to an FSUI post on X. "We urgently appeal to all concerned authorities, shipowners, flag state, and the Government of India to immediately secure their safety and arrange prompt repatriation," says the post.

On July 25, Indian time, Palau-flagged General Cargo Ship AGN RAGNAR was reportedly attacked by three drones while exiting the Bystre Mouth of the Danube river into the Black Sea. During the attack, two Indian nationals, Chandra Ram Dubey (Ordinary Seaman) and Gupta Kumar Deepak (Ordinary Seaman), reportedly jumped overboard and are still missing. Search operations were later called off.

Centre reissues draft on Western Ghats eco-zone

Move comes amid the continuing differences with six States over the areas to be included in the ecologically sensitive area; States worried about notification's impact on farming, infrastructure

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

The Union Environment Ministry has reissued, for the seventh time in over a decade, its draft notification proposing an ecologically sensitive area (ESA) across the Western Ghats, after the previous draft lapsed on July 27 without being finalised.

The latest draft, issued on July 27, 2026, will remain open for public objections for 60 days before the Centre considers issuing a final notification. The notification reiterates that once finalised, it would prohibit mining, quarrying, sand mining, new thermal power plants, certain industries and large construction projects within the ESA, while regulating activities such as hydel power generation.

The fresh notification underscores the Centre's inability to resolve long-standing differences with the six Western Ghats States — Gujarat, Maharashtra, Goa, Karnataka, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu — over the precise villages



The latest notification retains the proposed ecologically sensitive area at 56,825.7 sq. km, spread across the six States. FILE PHOTO

and regions that should be included within the eco-sensitive zone. The States had raised concerns over the impact of the ESA declaration on agriculture, plantations, infrastructure, and development.

The notification itself notes that an expert committee constituted in 2022 is continuing to examine objections from the States regarding "the correct names and area of villages to be included in the ecologically sensitive area" as well as other suggestions submitted by the State governments.

The latest notification

retains the proposed ESA at 56,825.7 sq. km, spread across the six States, with Karnataka accounting for 20,668 sq. km, Maharashtra 17,340 sq. km, Kerala 9,993.7 sq. km, Tamil Nadu 6,914 sq. km, Goa 1,461 sq. km and Gujarat 449 sq. km.

No changes

A comparison of the latest draft with the previous notification issued in July 2024 shows no substantive changes in the notified area, State-wise extent or regulatory provisions. The list of villages proposed for inclusion also remains un-

changed in places highlighted during earlier consultations. For instance, the 13 villages in Kerala's Wayanad district across Mananthavady, Sulthan Batherly and Vythiri taluks that figured in the previous draft continue to be included in the 2026 notification.

The dispute over protecting the Western Ghats dates back to 2011, when a panel chaired by late ecologist Madhav Gadgil recommended that the entire 1,29,000 sq. km mountain chain be treated as ecologically sensitive, with graded levels of protection. Following objections from the States, a high-level working group chaired by K. Kasturirangan reviewed the proposal and recommended that about 37% of the Western Ghats, covering 59,940 sq. km of natural landscape, be designated an ESA. The notification records that Kerala subsequently carried out its own field verification exercise, reducing the proposed ESA within the State from 13,108 sq. km recommended by the high-level working group to 9,993.7 sq. km.

The Hindu Group bags 7 awards at MADDYS 2026

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Hindu Group's flagship campaign "The Hindu Written by Journalists" bagged the Grand Prix recognition in the "Digital Creatives" or "Content-Digital Videos (Short Form)" category at the MADDYS 2026, the 44th Madras Advertising Club Awards, alongside two Gold awards, one each for "Media Innovation (OOH and Ambient Media)" and "Media-Integrated Campaign" categories.

It also secured a Gold in "Print Craft-Copywriting for 'Unseen Labour'", a compelling Labour Day communication. It also won two Bronze awards in "Print Craft-Copywriting for 'Power of Attorney'", a World Wildlife Day communication advocating for wildlife conservation, and in "Cause Advertising & Public Service-Print Campaign for 'Stub the Habit'", a World No Tobacco Day campaign that encouraged people to quit smoking through innovative storytelling. In addition to its seven MADDYS wins, The Hindu Group was also recognised at the Digital MADDYS, where it was named "Client of the Year".

Panel on SC status for Dalit converts yet to submit report

Abhinav Lakshman
NEW DELHI

More than a month after the Justice K.G. Balakrishnan (ret'd)-led commission finished its study to examine whether Scheduled Caste status can be accorded to Dalit converts, its report has not yet been submitted, *The Hindu* has learnt.

Sources aware of the developments said that while the report was readied last month, "annexures" for it are being "put together" and that the report will likely be submitted "soon". Significantly, the last deadline for the commission's work expired on June 10, and the government has since not issued any notification extending the time for the panel's work.

The three-member Commission of Inquiry was constituted in October 2022.

Study finds multiple dengue virus strains circulating together in India

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

India may be entering a more perilous phase in its dengue epidemic, with multiple strains of the virus now circulating simultaneously across much of the country, raising concerns over an increased risk of severe disease, and posing fresh challenges for the rollout of future dengue vaccination programmes.

A two-year nationwide surveillance study by the Indian Council of Medical Research's (ICMR) Virus Research and Diagnostic Laboratory (VRDL) network found that all four dengue virus serotypes are circulating together in several parts of the country, with nearly one in 14 patients infected with more than one serotype at the same time.

The study, titled "Pan-India Molecular Surveillance of Dengue Serotypes,"



Surveillance of serotypes would be critical as vaccine effectiveness varies against different dengue strains.

2023-2025", analysed 6,889 laboratory-confirmed dengue samples from 45 laboratories across 25 States and Union Territories and found that DENV-2 remained the predominant serotype, accounting for over half of all infections. However, researchers said the broader concern was the widespread co-circulation of multiple serotypes, indicating

dengue hyper-endemicity. Eight States and Union Territories reported the presence of all four serotypes, while 15 reported three circulating simultaneously. Around 7% of patients were infected with two or more dengue serotypes concurrently.

The study also found that patients with concurrent infections were more likely to develop severe manifestations of dengue, including dangerously low platelet counts, bleeding complications and severe joint pain. While the findings need confirmation through long-term clinical studies, they suggest that simultaneous infection with multiple strains could worsen disease severity.

The emergence of hyper-endemic transmission has implications beyond clinical care, the report notes. India currently has no dengue vaccine in its Universal Immunisation Programme, although indigenous vaccine candidates are in advanced stages of clinical development, and an internationally approved vaccine recently received regulatory clearance for import and sale in India.

Continuous surveillance of serotypes would be critical because vaccine effectiveness varies against different dengue strains, and shifts in the dominant serotype could influence both outbreak intensity and vaccine performance, researchers said. "Apart from routine steps taken to prevent mosquito breeding, there is certainly a need to incorporate the dengue vaccine into public health programmes, initially targeting endemic areas," Gautam Menon, Professor of Physics and Biology, Ashoka University, said, speaking of the need for continuous surveillance.

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The event will serve as a platform for developers, investors, architects, urban planners, technology experts, and policymakers

The Hindu real estate, infra summit to be held tomorrow

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Rapidly expanding city infrastructure, urbanisation, and the rise of integrated communities have led to a recent increase in demand from both end-users and investors in Chennai. With the city's real estate sector entering a definitive growth phase, *The Hindu* is organising The Real Estate & Infrastructure Summit, 2026, presented by Casagrand in association with Adissia Developers, on July 30 at the ITC Grand Chola in Chennai.

The summit will be inaugurated by Tamil Nadu's Minister for Housing and Urban Development B. Rajkumar, who will deliver the keynote address on the future of urban development and infrastructure in India. The event will serve as a platform for developers, investors, architects, urban planners, technology experts, and policymakers



to exchange ideas on the opportunities and challenges emerging across the real estate and infrastructure sectors.

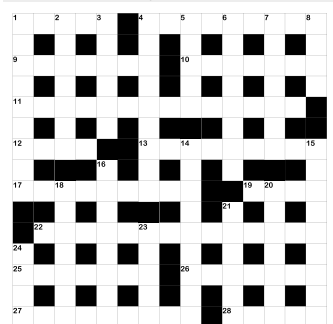
The summit will feature keynote addresses and discussions by prominent voices from the real estate and infrastructure sectors, including M.N. Arun, managing director, Casagrand; M.V. Manikandan, founder and CMD, Adissia Developers; and members of CREDAI Chennai.

Business leaders and experts are expected to examine the most significant trends transforming India's urban landscape, such as the rapid expansion of Global Capability Centres (GCCs), growing role of artificial intelligence in construction, emergence of new investment corridors, and the luxury housing boom. The summit aims to facilitate meaningful networking among industry stakeholders, offering participants an opportunity to engage with the decision-makers expected to shape India's real estate and infrastructure landscape over the coming decade.

Associate Partners: Navin's and Mindspace REIT; Banking Partner: State Bank of India; Insurance Partner: United India Insurance; Academic Partner: Savetha College of Architecture & Design; Industry Partner: CREDAI Chennai; Television Partner: Puthiya Thalaimurai; Digital News Partner: The Federal. Participation is by invitation only. Those interested may register by visiting www.thestreetline.com/thre2026 or by scanning the QR code.



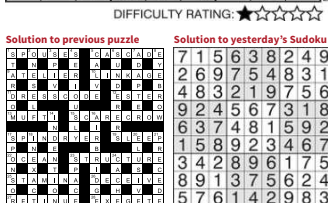
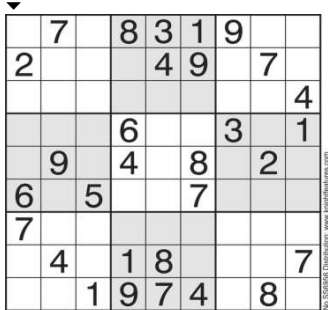
THE CROSSWORD 14858



- ACROSS
- Everybody who's ruled regularly (5)
 - Piano finale in *Sholay*, amidst Gabbar getting shot and beheaded (4,5)
 - Salamander all too excited about kiss (7)
 - Sorcerers with headless reptiles (7)
 - I'll tell Betty it's cooked slowly (6,2,6)

- Standard from Ronaldo — scored on both sides upon returning (4)
 - Fruit vending station software on phone essentially stalled and rejected touch (5-4)
 - They hurt referees badly, inspiring a dash of fear (9)
 - Main man in the woman's heart (4)
 - What someone said, as reported in bleak court records backing filed copy (8,6)
 - Was easy to relocate shipping routes (7)
 - Perhaps one by poet Eliot? No withdrawing in front of audience! (7)
 - Feral spy moving around quietly with thin, attractive agents of death (9)
 - Procedure decimated pests (5)
- DOWN
- Wife in lake, swimming next to grandsons on vacation (they're not very strong) (9)
 - Bird in kangaroo's territory (7)
 - Meadow-grazer eating weathered old drawing (6)
 - With two tips, a bit able, somehow, to hold bees' end (9)
 - Joint recycling and waste processing centre? (5)
 - Watch test while skimming newspapers (8)
 - Trailer, U/A-certified, reviewed: shows harmless jellyfish (7)
 - Record example of single-hop Caesar cipher mapping? (4)
 - Places medicines outside upwardly mobile infants' limits (9)
 - Let's shoot randomly? That's ineffective (9)
 - Adventures in a tavern featuring Greek wine (8)
 - Dream lover, stay through storm! (7)
 - Cheer a tense, boring cricket team, mostly (7)
 - Resorts to extremes of malicious attacks (6)
 - Follow Peruvian river around American country to the north (5)
 - Former Kent captain, Iqbal from Pakistan? No chance! (2,2)

SUDOKU



FAITH

Alavandar's Chatushloki

Swami Alavandar, an erudite scholar, great Acharya and philosopher, is well-known as Yamunacharya. His most prominent work is Chatushloki. *Chatus* means four, *loki* means hymns. That is, the four slokas in praise of Goddess Mahalakshmi, said Tirukudanthai Dr. Venkatesh in a discourse. Periyavachan Pillai and Swami Vedanta Desika composed scholarly commentary on the work of Alavandar's Chatushloki. Periyavachan Pillai, in his commentary, explains that every Sri Vaishnava should recite and contemplate nine sacred teachings every day as part of their spiritual practice. The first three constitute the Rahasya Trayam, the three sacred secrets. They are the Thirumantira, the Dvaya Mantra, and the Charama Sloka from the Bhagavad Gita. The fourth and fifth are the two Varaha Charama slokas spoken by Lord Varaha to Bhoomi Devi (Mother of Earth).

The remaining four, making up the sixth through the ninth, are the Chatushloki. The first verse explains Goddess Mahalakshmi's supreme sovereignty. Her divine spouse is Lord Narayana Himself. The second verse narrates Her infinite glory and forgiveness. Alavandar highlights that Goddess Lakshmi's grace and glory are so vast that even Lord Narayana cannot set boundaries. The third verse expounds the power of Her grace from the corner of an eye known as "Lakshmi Kataksham". In the final and fourth verse, Alavandar explains how Mother Lakshmi accompanies Lord Narayana across all dimensions and incarnations. Lakshmi manifests in a form perfectly corresponding to Him, ensuring that Her divine grace is always available to protect and delight all devotees.

WASHINGTON

Netanyahu visits White House for first Trump talks during Iran war



Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu visited the White House on Tuesday for his first in-person talks with President Donald Trump since the Iran war began. The meeting — which the White House described as “positive and productive” — took place behind closed doors and lasted for about an hour and a half. **AFP**

WASHINGTON

U.S. begins review of force presence in Europe amid Trump ire on NATO



The United States began reviewing its military presence in Europe on Monday, officials said, after U.S. Secretary of War Pete Hegseth told his NATO allies that Washington was planning such an analysis. President Donald Trump has repeatedly lashed out against European allies over their response to his war in Iran. **AP**

ATHENS

Months of cross-border fighting killed 500 Afghan civilians: UN



Cross-border fighting between Pakistan and Afghanistan has killed nearly 500 civilians in Afghanistan and wounded over 1,000 others between October and the end of June, the United Nations said on Tuesday. Pakistan accuses Afghanistan of harbouring militants who carry out deadly attacks in Pakistan. Kabul denies the allegation. **AP**

ISLAMABAD

14 killed, dozens injured in clashes with security forces in PoK: JAAC



At least 14 activists of the banned Joint Awami Action Committee were killed and over two dozen injured in clashes with security personnel during the first phase of elections in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), the organisation claimed on Tuesday. Officials accused JAAC protesters of opening fire on security personnel. **PTI**

‘Many people’ feared trapped in mall after earthquake in Japan

A 7.1-magnitude earthquake struck Japan, reaching the highest level of seven on Shindo shaking scale; a shopping mall in Kashima was reported to have people trapped inside after its second floor collapsed in a fire; over 100 reportedly injured

Agence France-Presse
TOKYO

“Many people” were feared trapped in a stricken shopping mall in Japan late on Tuesday, authorities said, after a major earthquake toppled buildings, sparked fires and reportedly injured more than 100.

Private broadcaster TBS reported that a “considerable number” were feared dead inside the mall in the town of Kashima after the fire brigade said that the second floor collapsed in the 7.1-magnitude tremor.

Public broadcaster NHK cited police sources as say-



Rescue workers conducting a search and rescue operation at a shopping centre in Kashima Town, Japan on Tuesday. **REUTERS**

ing that between 20 and 30 employees could not be contacted, showing footage of emergency vehicles with flashing red lights outside.

The police said they could not confirm any fatalities inside the building. *Kyodo* News reported that four persons had been taken to hospital, all of them

conscious. Multiple people were also believed to be unaccounted for at a Japan Paper Industries factory where the tip of a chimney fell down, *NHK* reported, citing sources.

One person was killed when a house collapsed during the quake, *Kyodo* reported.

Widespread damage Footage elsewhere in the southwestern Kumamoto region on the island of Kyushu aired by *NHK* showed several blazes, damaged bridges, a derailed cargo train and a number of houses threatening to topple over.

The tremor had a mag-

nitude of 7.1, the Japan Meteorological Agency (JMA) said, but reached the highest level of seven on Japan’s Shindo scale of shaking. A succession of aftershocks followed, including one with a magnitude of 6.1.

Many roads were closed and high-speed shinkansen train services were suspended in the region. Kumamoto airport was closed before being re-opened on Tuesday evening.

“We are still assessing the extent of injuries and property damage, but I have been informed that there have already been several injuries,” Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi said.

Oman presents Iran with plan for fees to use Hormuz

Reuters
DUBAI

Oman has presented Iran with a plan backed by Gulf states to manage the Strait of Hormuz, including collecting voluntary fees for using it, a Gulf source and a Western diplomat told *Reuters* on Tuesday. The plan could serve as a basis to end the disruption through the strait caused by the U.S.-Israeli war on Iran.

U.S. President Donald Trump, who abruptly called off a two-week bombing campaign over the weekend in his latest strategic U-turn, said there were “good talks” under way with Iran but threatened to restart strikes unless negotiations deliver. Iran denies seeking to resume talks with the United States. Under the Omani



The plan could serve as a basis to end the disruption through the strait caused by the U.S.-Israeli war on Iran. **REUTERS**

proposal, Iran would not exercise sole control and fees would be voluntary.

The system would be analogous to one in place on Asia’s Strait of Malacca, where Indonesia, Malaysia and Singapore ask ships to pay voluntary contributions to fund navigation, environmental protection and search-and-rescue op-

erations. The Western diplomat compared it to a voluntary carbon tax for flights, where anyone buying a plane ticket can choose to tick a box if they want to pay to offset their emissions.

The Gulf source said that there had been no formal response from Iran to the proposal.

‘U.S. bombers used Israel’s bases to hit Iran’

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Israeli Defence Minister Israel Katz on Tuesday said that American warplanes used Israeli bases during their attacks on Iran, reiterating that his country was prepared to retaliate if targeted.

Fighting between the U.S. and Iran has been paused since Friday after

13 nights of U.S. strikes on the Islamic republic, after an April ceasefire collapsed. Israel has not taken part in the latest round of hostilities in the war that began in late February with a wave of U.S.-Israeli strikes on Iran.

“The fact is that, at the moment — and this could change within an hour — the Iranians are firing at everything in the region ex-



Israel Katz

cept one country: the State of Israel,” Mr. Katz told *Israel’s* right-wing *Channel*

14. “They know that American aircraft are taking off from here to carry out strikes,” he added.

“This does not mean we know what will happen tomorrow; it means we know what our response will be. I announced it, the Prime Minister announced it, and we made it absolutely clear: if Israel comes under fire, we will strike back with full force,” he said.

Zelenskyy hails ‘good’ talks with Trump

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy hailed a “good meeting” with U.S. counterpart Donald Trump at the White House on Tuesday, saying they discussed licences to produce Patriot air-defence interceptors and ways to revive negotiations with Russia.



Volodymyr Zelenskyy

Mr. Zelenskyy spent just over an hour with Mr. Trump, in talks that came

with Kyiv and Moscow intensifying long-range strikes and U.S.-led diplomatic efforts to end the war stalled.

“Thank you for everything we do together to protect the lives of Ukrainians and advance peace,” Mr. Zelenskyy said afterward in a statement on X.

“The President and I discussed licenses for Patriot interceptors produc-

tion and several other ideas that could help,” he added. “We also spoke about diplomacy — it’s important that the diplomatic process be reinvigorated.”

White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt described the meeting as “positive and productive”.

Mr. Zelenskyy said he had also offered Mr. Trump his condolences over senator Lindsey Graham’s death.

We are not anyone’s proxy force: Iranian Kurdish party

Stanley Johny



Rivar Abdanan

The Kurdistan Free Life Party (PJAK), an armed Kurdish group and political party based in Iran’s Kurdish region, says it will not join the U.S.-Israel war against Iran unless the “existence of the Kurdish people comes under threat”, insisting that it is “not anyone’s proxy force” but a movement seeking a democratic transformation of Iran.

In an email interview with *The Hindu*, Rivar Abdanan, a PJAK spokesperson and member of the party’s Leadership Council, said the group rejects being viewed merely as a military actor and instead seeks to build “a democratic, self-administered society” in Kurdistan while working towards “the establishment of a democratic republic throughout Iran”.

Mr. Abdanan said PJAK’s military posture is guided by self-defence and political strategy rather than opportunism. “The Islamic Republic wants to drag us into a long and exhausting war,” he said, adding that the party wants to preserve Kurdish political and

war”. While stressing that PJAK does not believe war is a path to democracy, he argued that the roots of the conflict lie in the Islamic Republic’s “repressive domestic policies and its expansionist policies across the region”. He said the group views “pressure on this dictatorial regime and strikes against its centres of repression” as positive, provided civilians are not harmed and the future right to self-determination of Iran’s peoples is not undermined.

On relations with Washington and Tel Aviv, Mr. Abdanan said PJAK keeps “diplomatic channels open to all governments and political actors” whose engagement serves Kurdish interests and supports “the establishment of a democratic political system in Iran”.

At the same time, he noted that many Iranian Kurds remain sceptical of both powers, citing what he called America’s inconsistent policies towards Syrian Kurds and the lasting memory of Israel’s alleged role in the capture of Kurdish leader Abdullah Öcalan.

RAJASTHAN RAJYA VIDYUT PRASARAN NIGAM LIMITED

NOTICE INVITING e-BIDS
Online e-bids are invited for installation of 132KV GSS along with associated Lines/Bays/Capacitor Banks including supply of all Equipments (except Power Transformer and ACSR conductor), materials, erection (including civil works), testing & commissioning as detailed below:

1. No. 132 KV GSS Deepda (Sedwa) (Distt-Barnet), and associated lines 35KM 132KV D/C Deepda (Sedwa)-Gohar ka Tala (Dhanau) line and 2No 132KV Bay at 132KV GSS Gohar ka Tala and 15-43 MWAR, 33KV Capacitor Bank at 132KV GSS Deepda.
2. No. 132 KV GSS Gohar ka Tala (Dhanau) (Distt-Barnet) and associated lines 30 KM 132KV D/C Gohar ka Tala (Dhanau)-Sawa line and 2 No. of 132 KV feeder bay at 132 KV GSS Sawa and 15-43 MWAR, 33KV Capacitor Bank at 132KV GSS Gohar ka Tala.

The detailed NB and Bid document/Specification are available for viewing/downloading on the website: <http://eproc.raajasthan.gov.in>. Details of NBs are available on website: <http://energy.raajasthan.gov.in/rvpn>.

Any extension in bid submission/opening date (if any) will be floated/uploaded on <http://eproc.raajasthan.gov.in>; <http://energy.raajasthan.gov.in/rvpn> & <http://eproc.raajasthan.gov.in> only. **Superintending Engineer (Proc-II)**

Raj/Samwadi/276/7816 R.R.V.P.N./78-7701/2026

Kalyan Singh Super Specialty Cancer Institute
C.G. City, Sultanpur Road, Lucknow-226002
(An Autonomous Institute of the Govt. of Uttar Pradesh)

Website: <https://cancerinstitute.edu.in> Email: jdmn.sacii@gmail.com

TENDER NOTICE

On-line offers are invited through Custom bids on GeM portal. The GEM bid Nos. are given herewith:

1. GEM/2026/B/7807803 dated: 27.07.2026 for the Item-Slide Cabinet
2. GEM/2026/B/7807764 dated: 27.07.2026 for the Item-Cold Plate
3. GEM/2026/B/7808661 dated: 27.07.2026 for the Item-composite Bipolar Resectoscope set with PCNL and URS (Flexible chip up tip Video Cystoscopy and Ureteroscope)
4. GEM/2026/B/7810681 dated: 27.07.2026 for the Item-5 Para (7 Para) Monitors wall mounted with one Central Cardiac Station

Offer are invited from Original Equipment Manufacturer/Direct Importers/Authorized Distributors (declared by principal firm only) for the supply & installation of aforementioned Equipment. Bidders should submit their Representation only on GeM Portal regarding Equipment within time frame provided by GeM. The vendors are required to submit their offers on GeM portal only in two bids system i.e. Technical and Financial bid as per norms of GeM Portal with terms and conditions as mentioned against bidding documents.

For more detailed information you may please visit the GeM portal www.gem.gov.in or our website <https://cancerinstitute.edu.in> for reference only.

The Director reserves the right to accept or reject any tender in part or full without assigning any reason therefor.

Advt. No. KSSSCI/Tender-10/2026-27 **Joint Director**

Odisha Police
Office of the D.G. & I.G. of Police, Odisha, Cuttack
Tel: 0671-2304001 Website: police.odisha.gov.in Email: jeons.official@rediffmail.com
RFP No. 10-RFP-Online UPS - 2026-2027 Date: 27.07.2026

Online Bids through e-Tender Portal <https://tendersodisha.gov.in> are invited from the eligible bidders for Online UPS during the CFY 2026-27 as per the schedule mentioned below.

SLNo.	Name of Item	Approximate quantity
1.	Online UPS	01 Set

Events	Date
RFP Issue Date	27.07.2026
RFP Submission Due Date and time	02.08.2026
Date & Time of Opening of Technical Bids	18.08.2026
Bid to RA enabled	Yes
Tender Document fee ((Non-refundable Rs.500/-Rs.500)+ 18% GST (Rs. 90/-))	In favour of A.I.G. of Police (Prov.), Odisha, Cuttack payable at Cuttack. (Demand Draft)
EMD (Earnest Money Deposit) Rs: 15,000/-	In favour of A.I.G. of Police (Prov.), Odisha, Cuttack payable at Cuttack. (Demand Draft)

The bid document with all information relating to the bidding process including cost of bid document, Prequalification criteria and terms & conditions are available in the websites: <https://tendersodisha.gov.in>. The Authority reserves the right to accept / reject any part thereof or all the bids without assigning any reason therefor.

A.I.G. of Police (Provisioning), Odisha, Cuttack.
(Tender Calling Authority)
DPR-120611/2026/126-27/0018

BANGALORE WATER SUPPLY AND SEWERAGE BOARD
INVITATION FOR TENDER
(Through KPP Portal Only)

BWSSB invites Tenders in Two Stage Tender System from eligible contractors for the following works.

Sl No.	Name of the Works	Amount put to Tender
		EMD Amount

Office of the Chief Engineer (West), 6th Floor, Cauvery Bhavan, K.G Road, Bengaluru- 560 009.

No:BWSSB/EIC/CE(W)/ACE(W)/H/DCE(W)/TA(W)/2142/2026-27 Dated:28.07.2026

1. Work of providing and laying of 300mm & 100mm dia DI Water pipeline due to White Topping by GBA at 9th Main from 24th Cross up to 13th Cross, BSK 2nd Stage coming under Ganesh Mandira Service Station of AEE W-4-3 Sub division. **₹ 11.441 Lakhs**
2. Work of providing and laying 300mm Dia RCC NP3 Class & 230mm Dia GSW Sewer line for proposed white topping road at 9th Main 24th Cross & 21st Main up to 13th cross comes under Ganesh Mandira Service Station of AEE W-4-3 Sub Division. **₹ 2.00 Lakhs**

No:BWSSB/EIC/CE(W)/ACE(W)/H/DCE(W)/TA(W)/2142/2026-27 Dated:28.07.2026

1. Work of providing and laying 300mm Dia RCC NP3 Class & 230mm Dia GSW Sewer line for proposed white topping road at 9th Main 24th Cross & 21st Main up to 13th cross comes under Ganesh Mandira Service Station of AEE W-4-3 Sub Division. **₹ 156.12 Lakhs**
2. Work of providing and laying 300mm Dia RCC NP3 Class & 230mm Dia GSW Sewer line for proposed white topping road at 9th Main 24th Cross & 21st Main up to 13th cross comes under Ganesh Mandira Service Station of AEE W-4-3 Sub Division. **₹ 2.35 Lakhs**

For all the above works, the Last date and time for Receipt of tenders: **12-08-2026 upto 17:00 hours**. Tender will be opened on **13-08-2026 after 17:30 hours**.

Sd/- Chief Engineer (West)

The details regarding participation in the e-procurement portal process can be obtained by logging on to <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> For further details contact the above signed officer during working hours.

DPR/CP/1857/CCL/2026-27

COMMANDING SHOW

Jadumani storms into semifinals, ensures India another medal



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Jadumani Singh stormed into the semifinals of the men's 55kg boxing event with a commanding 5-0 victory over Zambia's Mwengo Mwale at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow on Tuesday. The Indian, who looked fluent throughout the bout, is assured of at least a bronze medal.

MIXED BAG

Vishal qualifies for the 400m semifinal even as Rajesh bows out



X@MEDIA, SAI

National record holder Vishal T.K. (46.49s) kept India's medal hopes alive in the men's 400m after qualifying for the semifinals, while compatriot Rajesh Ramesh (47.43s) narrowly missed the cut in the athletics competition at the Commonwealth Games on Tuesday. The 22-year-old Vishal finished second in Round 1 Heat 6.

MOVING ON

Ten Doeschate departs from India's coaching staff



FILE PHOTO: R. RAGU

Ryan Ten Doeschate has stepped down as India's assistant coach, bringing an end to a stint with the team that began alongside Gautam Gambhir's appointment as head coach in July 2024. The Dutchman is understood to have tendered his resignation following the conclusion of India's recent tour of England — **Amol Karhadkar**.

ALMOST THERE

West Indies one wicket away from winning the opening Test



AFP

West Indies was one wicket away from beating Pakistan when tea was called on the fourth day of the opening Test in Tarouba on Tuesday. **The scores:** West Indies 311 & 181 in 54.5 overs (Mohammad Abbas 5/22) vs Pakistan 282 & 114/9 in 39 overs (Babar Azam 53 batting, Jayden Seales 4/20) **at tea**.



Ending a drought: Sharmila and Shilpa ended a 20-year wait for a CWG para athletics medal, PTI

Sharmila claims gold in para shot put F57

CWALTH GAMES

Press Trust of India
GLASGOW

Sharmila Dhankar scripted history on Monday as she won India's first para athletics gold medal in the Commonwealth Games, clinching the top spot in the women's shot put F57 event here.

The 40-year-old produced a season-best throw of 9.81m to end India's 20-year wait for a para athletics medal in the CWG.

Another Indian, Shilpa Shyla, was awarded the bronze medal following an Indian protest in controversial circumstances. Shyla had produced a personal best effort of 7.26m.

Nigeria's Eucharika Iyiazi was initially placed at the bronze medal position but after a protest and official review, her only valid mark was adjudged a foul. That led to Shyla being upgraded to bronze from initial

fourth place. However, it is likely that a counter protest may also be launched by Nigeria.

F57 classification is for athletes with lower limb impairments, limb deficiencies, or reduced muscle power.

Infected with polio on her left leg at the age of two, Sharmila won a gold medal in the Fazzia International Para Athletics Championship this year. She also took part in the 2022 Birmingham Games and finished fourth.

Meanwhile, India's Srihari Nataraj qualified for the 100m backstroke semifinals but veteran Sajan Prakash failed to go past the Heats of 50m butterfly event on Tuesday. Srihari finished fifth in his Heat and 13th overall with a timing of 55.58 seconds.

The 16 fastest swimmers advanced to the semifinals. Sajan, however, failed to qualify after finishing eighth in his Heat and 28th overall.

He managed a total lift of 330kg, just 1kg behind Malaysia's Muhammad Erry Hidayat, who created Games records in clean and jerk (184) and total (330). Ajaya, too, produced a Games record of 149 in snatch while Hidayat managed 147. Ajaya lifted 181 in clean and jerk.

"I should have done better. I dedicate the medal to Indian Weightlifting Federation, coaches, support staff and my father. I followed the sport after seeing my father who has been my inspiration. I wanted to win gold but couldn't. I will try to win it next time," Ajaya said.

Nirupama Devi failed to clear 123kg on all three clean and jerk attempts, resulting in a no-mark in the section and a DNF in the women's 63kg final. She was placed fifth after snatch with a best lift of 93kg.

rubber to confirm India's entry into the semifinals. The Indian women had eased past Sri Lanka 3-0 earlier in the afternoon.

The defining performance of the tie, though, came from Olympian Sutirtha Mukherjee. Locked in a tense battle against Constantina Psihogios in the third singles, Sutirtha relied on her experience and timely winners to edge a gripping five-game contest. She clinched the tie 13-11.

Sreeja lost to Liu as Australia made it 2-2 before Yashaswini sealed the tie. The Indian men, meanwhile, enjoyed a more comfortable outing against Australia. World No. 38 Manav Thakkar shrugged off a cut on his forehead — sustained after colliding with the umpire's desk during the second game — to complete his singles victory as India sealed the tie 3-0.

Kushare clinches a historic silver for India in high jump

The 31-year-old is the first from the country to finish second in the discipline at the Games; Jamaica's Beckford takes home the gold; injuries dash the hopes of Tejaswin and hurdler Shirse

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

For every attempt by Sarvesh Kushare in the men's high jump final of the Commonwealth Games at the Scotstoun Stadium here on Monday, the modest gathering of spectators responded with warm applause and cheers. But when the Indian stepped up for his third and final attempt at 2.28m in expectations of a gold medal — after Romaine Beckford had failed to clear the same height in his final attempt — sepulchral silence descended over the stadium. It was evident that the crowd wanted the 31-year-old Indian to win.

However, it wasn't to be. Kushare settled for the silver medal — the first for India in able-bodied athletics at this Games. It was also the first silver by an Indian high jumper at the quadrennial event.

Beckford had sailed past 2.25m in his first try, while the Indian National record holder managed the same height only in his third, handing the Jamaican the gold on countback.

"I am happy to win a medal in my second Commonwealth Games. The cold weather affected my warm-up and warm-down routine. I was a bit con-



No time to relax: Kushare said he will now focus on the Asian Games. AFP

fused, but it was a good learning experience and a lot of fun. I won't relax now and will focus on the Asian Games," said Kushare.

However, it turned out to be a disappointing day for Tejaswin Sankar, the bronze medalist at the 2022 Birmingham Commonwealth Games.

Initially, there was confusion when the official Commonwealth Games website displayed a DNS (Did Not Start) against his name.

When queried, officials said it was a "technical glitch". A few minutes later, spectators saw Tejaswin on the stadium's giant screen

waving at them. The 27-year-old failed in his opening attempt at 2.05m before retiring from the competition.

Later, Tejaswin said he withdrew because of severe pain caused by tendonitis in his knee.

"I think I've always had tendonitis in my knee. There isn't a high jumper in the world who hasn't suffered tendonitis. It was just one of those days. I was confident of doing well and winning a medal. In fact, I was feeling good and was in great shape during my warm-up," he said while trying to control his tears.

Tejaswin said he would

now focus on recovering in time for his next event, the decathlon on Friday.

"I'll try to fix this injury. I'm not on vacation. There are two days before my next event, and I'll start my recovery," he said.

Jack Kimani of England finished third (2.2m), while the third Indian in the field, Adarsh Ram, came fifth (2.15).

Meanwhile, Tejas Shirse finished eighth and last in the men's 110m hurdles final in 15.39 seconds and was seen limping towards the end of the race.

"I felt pain in my left ankle during the warm-up before the race," Shirse said.

Ajaya wins silver, does one better than dad

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

Ajaya Babu grew up accompanying his father, Valluri Srinivasa Rao, to weightlifting competitions, learning the finer aspects of the sport from him. Inspired by Rao, who won a bronze medal in the men's 56kg category at the 2010 Commonwealth Games in New Delhi, Ajaya arrived in Glasgow for his debut

Games determined to make his dad proud.

He did exactly that, although he was left disappointed after missing the gold by a whisker in the men's 79kg event at the Scottish Event Campus here on Monday night.

The 21-year-old from Kondavelagada village in Andhra Pradesh's Vizianagaram district finished with the silver.

He managed a total lift

of 330kg, just 1kg behind Malaysia's Muhammad Erry Hidayat, who created Games records in clean and jerk (184) and total (330). Ajaya, too, produced a Games record of 149 in snatch while Hidayat managed 147. Ajaya lifted 181 in clean and jerk.

"I should have done better. I dedicate the medal to Indian Weightlifting Federation, coaches, support staff and my father. I fol-

lowed the sport after seeing my father who has been my inspiration. I wanted to win gold but couldn't. I will try to win it next time," Ajaya said.

Nirupama Devi failed to clear 123kg on all three clean and jerk attempts, resulting in a no-mark in the section and a DNF in the women's 63kg final. She was placed fifth after snatch with a best lift of 93kg.



Fine show: Ajaya produced a Games record of 149kg in snatch. GETTY IMAGES

Indian women edge past Australia, book semifinal spot

CWALTH TT

Amol Karhadkar
NEW DELHI

India overcame a spirited Australia to begin the second stage of the women's tennis event at the 22nd Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships with a hard-fought victory at the Thyagaraja Sports Complex on Tuesday.

The evening session marked the start of the second stage — effectively the Super Eight — and Australia ensured the top seed was made to work for every



Minor scare: Manav being treated by doctors after hurting his forehead during the match against Australia. AMOL KARHADKAR

point. Yangzi Liu, the high-ranked Australian singles player, was the stand-out performer, racing past both Yashaswini Ghorpade and Sreeja Akula without dropping a game.

Yashaswini, however, bounced back admirably. Showing remarkable composure after her opening defeat, the youngster outlasted the experienced Min Hyung Jee in the deciding

rubber to confirm India's entry into the semifinals.

The Indian women had eased past Sri Lanka 3-0 earlier in the afternoon.

The defining performance of the tie, though, came from Olympian Sutirtha Mukherjee.

Locked in a tense battle against Constantina Psihogios in the third singles, Sutirtha relied on her experience and timely winners to edge a gripping five-game contest. She clinched the tie 13-11.

Sreeja lost to Liu as Australia made it 2-2 before Yashaswini sealed the tie. The Indian men, meanwhile, enjoyed a more comfortable outing against Australia. World No. 38 Manav Thakkar shrugged off a cut on his forehead — sustained after colliding with the umpire's desk during the second game — to complete his singles victory as India sealed the tie 3-0.

G. Sathyan was drawn from the men's singles competition. Sathyan confirmed to *The Hindu* that he will, however, compete in the men's doubles alongside Harmeet Desai and in the mixed doubles with Sreeja. "Both these events will serve as preparation for the

Asian Games," he said.

Top results: Second stage: Women: India bt Australia 3-2 (Yashaswini Ghorpade lost to Yangzi Liu 13-15, 9-11, 5-11; Sreeja Akula bt Min Hyung Jee 12-10, 7-11, 11-5, 11-9; Sutirtha Mukherjee bt Constantina Psihogios 11-8, 9-11, 8-11, 11-8, 13-11; Yangzi bt Sreeja 11-8, 11-5, 11-5; Yashaswini bt Min 11-5, 11-9, 11-8); India bt Sri Lanka 3-0; Canada bt Sri Lanka 3-0; Australia bt Canada 3-0.

Men: India bt Australia 3-0 (Manush Shah bt Nicholas Lum 11-7, 9-11, 12-10, 11-13, 11-3; Manav Thakkar bt Chulong Nie 11-7, 11-6, 11-4; G. Sathyan bt Aditya Sareen 11-9, 11-8, 11-8); Malaysia bt Maldives 3-1; Sri Lanka bt Namibia 3-0.

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

Off-spinner Saransh Jain has earned a maiden call-up to India's Test squad for a two-match series against Sri Lanka next month. The two Tests will be played in Galle (August 15-19) and Colombo (August 23-27). In preparation for the series, the Indian team will play a four-day practice match in Colombo from August 7.

Saransh's opportunity comes on the back of off-spinning all-rounder Washington Sundar sustaining a hamstring injury during the ODI series against England. The BCCI stated that Washington wasn't available for the first Test, and hence has been left out altogether.

Saransh, who plays for Madhya Pradesh in domestic cricket, has picked up 188 scalps in 54 First Class appearances. The 33-year-old bats left-handed, and can contribute lower down the order. He has been part of the India-A set-up since February 2024.

Jadeja is back

After being rested for the one-off Test against Afghanistan in New Chandigarh in June, Ravindra Jadeja has made a return. The 37-year-old all-rounder is one of four spinners at Shubman Gill's disposal, along with Saransh, Manav Suthar and Kuldeep Yadav. Manav had thoroughly impressed with a match haul of seven for 62 on debut versus Afghanistan.

Asprit Bumrah has also returned to spearhead the pace attack, but his selec-



Saransh. FILE PHOTO: K. MURALI KUMAR

tion is subject to fitness. He missed the last ODI on the tour of England after sustaining an injury to his left knee. Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna and Gurnoor Brar are the other quicks in the 15-member squad.

In the batting unit, Sai Sudharsan's inclusion also came with a caveat that his fitness will have to be cleared by the BCCI's Centre of Excellence (CoE). On India-A's recent tour of Sri Lanka, comprising two four-day games, the south-paw had starred with two hundreds.

The squad: Shubman Gill (Capt.), K.L. Rahul (Vice-captain), Yashasvi Jaiswal, Rishabh Pant (wk), Sai Sudharsan, Dhruv Jurel (wk), Ravindra Jadeja, Kuldeep Yadav, Manav Suthar, Jasprit Bumrah, Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna, Gurnoor Brar, Devdutt Padikkal, and Saransh Jain.

Note: Sai Sudharsan and Bumrah's selection subject to fitness.

IN BRIEF



Gvardiol signs new five-year deal at Manchester City

Josko Gvardiol has signed a new five-year contract at Manchester City, the Premier League club announced on Tuesday. The Croatia international, whose previous deal had two years left to run, is now committed until 2031, with the option of an additional 12 months. The central defender made 122 appearances since arriving from RB Leipzig for £77 million in 2023.

Indian women go down to Malaysia in World jr. squash

Recently crowned World junior champion Anahat Singh won her contest but the Indian women's team went down fighting 1-2 to Malaysia in a World Squash junior team championship contest in Ontario, Canada. Anahat brushed aside the challenge from Whitney Wilson 11-2, 11-4, 11-5 in the concluding match after India lost the first two. In the opening match, Rudra Singh lost to Harleen Tan 5-11, 4-11, 6-11 while Anika Dubey was involved in a five-game thriller with Ye San Lee before going down 8-11, 11-8, 11-8, 10-12, 9-11. The team will next take on South Africa, while the men will face off against Kuwait.

Punjab FC signs forward Gurkirat and Nishchal

Punjab FC has bolstered its squad ahead of the 2026-27 Indian Super League (ISL) season with the double signing of forward Gurkirat Singh and defender Nishchal Chaudhan. Both players have signed two-year agreements that will keep them with the Shers until May 31, 2028.

Laver Cup: Ruud completes Team Europe's line-up

Europe's line-up for the Laver Cup in London has been completed with Norway's Casper Ruud named as the sixth member of the team to take on Team World. The World No. 13 will join Alexander Zverev, Carlos Alcaraz, Flavio Cobolli, Jakub Mensik and Rafael Nadal for the September 25-27 event. Team World, which will be captained by Andre Agassi, includes Alex de Minaur, Ben Shelton, Taylor Fritz, Learner Tien, Tommy Paul and Alexander Bublik.

Cucurella keeps De la Fuente on Tuesday pledge after WC win

Marc Cucurella revealed a new tattoo of coach Luis de la Fuente on his arm on Tuesday, keeping a promise he made before the country's World Cup win. The left-back vowed at the start of the summer to get a tattoo of the coach's face if Spain won the tournament. In the tattoo, De la Fuente is depicted wearing a suit and brandishing the World Cup.

LIVE TELECAST

CWG 2026: Day 6, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 1 p.m.
Durand Cup: Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 7 p.m.

TVS launches mini bikes to help grassroots two-wheeler racing

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

TVS Motor Company has launched the TVS Apache R 200 Mini to help youngsters take the first step into motorsports.

TVS gave away 10 mini bikes to the Madras Motor Sports Club in an event at the Madras International Karting Arena (MIKA) on Monday.

The purpose-built TVS Apache R 200 Mini will form the backbone of a structured rider development programme for aspiring racers aged 10-14 years, equipping them with professional racing skills under the guidance of experienced instructors and TVS Racing champions. They will also be provided with requisite safety gear.

For a long time, India has not had access to mini



The first step: TVS gave away 10 mini bikes to the Madras Motor Sports Club on Monday.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

bikes, which are crucial for riders' development and are enjoyed by their peers in Europe and Southeast Asia. These bikes promise to fill that gap, offering aspirants a chance to train their skills at an earlier age.

Young riders will be

Gukesh to defend his title against Sindarov in Geneva

The Indian had won the World championship by beating China's Ding in Singapore two years ago while his Uzbek rival earned the right to be the challenger after winning the Candidates

CHESS

P.K. Ajith Kumar

Geneva will host the World chess championship match between D. Gukesh and Javokhir Sindarov from November 25 to December 15. Chennai-based Gukesh had won the title by beating China's Ding Liren in Singapore two years ago while his Uzbek rival earned the right to be the challenger after winning the Candidates tournament.

Both players are aged 20, making it the youngest World title match in history.

Viswanathan Anand, world chess governing body FIDE's interim president, said several countries, including India, the United States, and Cyprus, had expressed interest to host the event.

"FIDE has decided to stage the match on neutral soil and bring it to Geneva,



It's a date! Sindarov will contest Gukesh for the world crown from November 25 to December 15.

FILE PHOTO

a city with a historic tradition of bringing nations and cultures together," said the five-time World champion.

"We look forward to welcoming the global chess community to Switzerland. The local chess fans will have the opportunity to experience world-class chess in per-

son, while fans around the globe can follow online as the duel for the highest title in chess unfolds."

President of the Swiss Chess Federation Andre Voegelin said it was a truly special day for Swiss chess.

"Twenty-two years after Brissago (2004 World title match), an event of major global chess significance is

returning to Switzerland. It's a moment that fills us with joy and motivation."

Though Gukesh has had to go through some tough times after becoming the youngest ever World champion, in sharp contrast to the rapid rise of Sindarov, it should be a fascinating match between the two young men.

Deschamps' tenure, which began in 2012, ended earlier this month after France finished fourth at the World Cup. He guided France to 2018 World Cup glory and the final four years later.

Zidane, Deschamps' teammate in the 1998 World Cup triumph, has been reading himself for the role since leaving Real Madrid in 2021.

"The France job was the only one I wanted," Zidane said after his unveiling at the FFF headquarters in Paris. "I've had offers over these four or five years to take charge of a club and I turned them all down for the French national team".

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City's Rodri sidelined for 'short period'

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Spain's World Cup-winning captain Rodri will be sidelined for a short period following a minor back surgery, Manchester City said on Tuesday. "Manchester City can confirm Rodri has undergone successful minor back surgery," the Premier League club said.

"He has undergone a procedure to address the issue and will begin a short period of rehabilitation."

Mancini will replace Gennaro Gattuso.

Malago announced the appointment during a Federal Council meeting.

"Mancini is the coach," he said before confirming the decision at a press conference.

"I believed that the best person to become head coach was Roberto Mancini."

The 61-year-old Mancini guided Italy to the European Championship title in 2021. He led Italy in 58 matches during his first spell and at club level has

managed Inter Milan, Fiorentina and Manchester City, where he spent three years and guided it to its first Premier League title in 2011-12.

Former FIGC technical director Paolo Maldini and adviser Leonardo resigned from their roles on Monday after their primary candidate for the Italy coach's position, Andrea Pirlo, had his appointment blocked due to his ties to a Russian betting firm.

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Zidane era begins for Les Bleus

FOOTBALL

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Zinedine Zidane was appointed France coach on Tuesday, as widely expected, following the departure of Didier Deschamps, the French Football Federation announced.

Zidane, 54, had long been viewed as the leading candidate for the role and had been waiting for an opportunity to take charge of the national team for several years.

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Zidane. REUTERS

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SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Abdusattorov upbeat about the Olympiad at home

The former World rapid champion admits being under pressure for the showpiece but believes the Uzbekistan squad is capable of going the distance; the 21-year-old says he will help Sindarov prepare for the World championship match against Gukesh in Geneva from November 25 to December 15

C. Shyam Sundar

The "children" of Visly Anand are on the loose! These were the words of Russian chess legend Garry Kasparov after Indian GM D. Gukesh had won the Candidates in circa 2024 before going on to capture the World title (later that year). He was referring to the growing legion of Indian chess players, especially those under the tutelage of Anand, who were taking the sport by storm.

The year (2024) was a golden one for India as it topped the Open and women's categories in the Budapest Olympiad before Gukesh dethroned Ding Liren in the championship match.

As the Indians were raising the bar, Uzbekistan was making

its presence felt with its players coming to the fore with impactful performances of their own.

Nodirbek Abdusattorov had probably struck the first blow for the Uzbeks, winning the World Rapid title in 2021 at the age of 17, becoming the youngest-ever to do so.

A year later in 2022, he was at the forefront as Uzbekistan emerged the surprise winner in the Open event in the Olympiad in Mamallapuram (near Chennai).

Abdusattorov and Javokhir Sindarov, who has emerged as a name to reckon within the last one year, will be spearheading Uzbekistan's charge to regain the gold in the upcoming Olympiad at home (in Samarkand).

The former World rapid champion, who was in Chennai recently for the Grand Masters tournament in the city, is confident of the team doing well in the Olympiad.

Gearing up

He said the squad had already held several training camps in Uzbekistan. The team is likely to comprise the Candidates winner Sindarov, Nodirbek Yakubboev and Shamsiddin Vokhidov besides Abdusattorov, with Mukhiddin Madaminov as the reserve.

This line-up, he said, could mount a serious challenge for the top prize.

"Our nation, our people will cheer for us. We understand that there will be a lot of pressure, and the expectations are very high," he said in an interaction. "But I think we are ready for this challenge. We have gained a lot of experience by playing under tension."

Abdusattorov said he would be helping out Sindarov as he prepares for the World championship match against Gukesh in Geneva (November 25 to December 15).

"I had joined his training camp for a week before the Candidates. For the upcoming World championship match, for sure, I will be part of his team. I will be training with him. From my perspective, he's my friend, he's close to me, and I will do my best to help him."

Sindarov, during an interaction with Indian journalists at Norway Chess, had said that he didn't even consider himself to be the best player in Uzbekistan and made known his admiration for Abdusattorov, who was a sort of a hero for the other players.

He also believes the camaraderie among the Uzbek players will help in the pursuit of an Olympiad gold at home.

"In Uzbekistan, we are all good friends. We try to take it in a good spirit. We don't see each other as competition or rivalry or enemies. We don't have any such ideas. Especially after becoming Olympiad champions in 2022, that

friendship became stronger," he further said. As a result, he said Uzbekistan had an advantage over other teams.

With the country's players performing well consistently over the years, Abdusattorov said, "We have grown up together when we were young and this generation is the golden generation for Uzbek chess."

That friendship is evident when Abdusattorov speaks glowingly about Sindarov. He said they have known each other since they were very young and competed in various age-group events.

"We played a lot against each other from our young age and it's good when you have a competition within your country because you get inspired, you learn from them, we try to train together and it helps us to improve and to show better results. Ultimately I think this is the main reason why we are having so many good results," he said.

Throwing his weight behind his friend and compatriot Sindarov, he said, "If Javokhir becomes the World champion, I think it's going to be an exceptional year for Uzbekistan."

Slight advantage for Gukesh

Turning his attention to the upcoming World Championship match between Sindarov and Gukesh, Abdusattorov said the Indian GM's experience (of having played the last title match) would give him a slight advantage.

"Gukesh's experience of playing the last World championship match gives him a little advantage. I think a lot depends on what kind of form and shape they will be in closer to the match. Also depends on preparation and some other aspects. But, it will be a lot of fun, a lot of entertainment for the chess world," he added.

Abdusattorov has enormous respect for former World champion Vladimir Kramnik, who was the captain of the Uzbekistan team during the last World Cup, saying he and the other players learnt a lot from him.

"Kramnik is a big figure in the chess world... he helped us individually with our openings. We learned a lot from him. He recommended some openings which fit my style."

About Anand's remark regarding the possibility of two Indians playing the World Championship match in the future, he said with a grin, "... In the long run, of course. Two Uzbeks, two Indians, two Americans. At some point, it's all possible."

Also, he is happy with the new Candidates' qualification criteria and the new format for the World Cup.

"Now, they are trying to get more spots... it's 224, so they are trying to get more spots and they are trying to reduce



B. VELANKANNI RAJ

the number of days. I think it's a good decision."

The 21-year-old Uzbek is in awe of the rise of Indian chess and said players like M. Pranesh, who scored over Gukesh in the Chennai Grand Masters, were incredibly strong.

"I think they (the Indian youngsters) are a bit underestimated and underrated. If they have a 2,650 rating, I see them as 2,700 already," said Abdusattorov.

He said Pranesh is a very good player and added that "He has huge potential and is also a very good Blitz player."

Candidates back in focus

Abdusattorov is planning to have a shot at the World title and aims to qualify for the next Candidates in this cycle.

"I'm looking forward to qualifying for the Candidates. But first of all, I want to enjoy the game and really get joy from it," said Abdusattorov, who failed to qualify for the Candidates tournament in 2026.

The young Uzbek chess star was also happy to return to Chennai, a happy hunting ground for him and even thought of going to the hotel where he had stayed during the 2022 Olympiad.

"I even checked how far away the hotel is where I stayed four years ago. I had an idea that maybe I can go to the hotel to relive some good memories..."

He has come a long way since those heady days in the southern city four years ago. Abdusattorov is now among the elite in chess as the 'golden generation' of Uzbekistan is primed and 'on the loose' to unleash its power on the global stage.

THE GIST

Abdusattorov and Sindarov, who has emerged as a name to reckon within the last one year, will be spearheading Uzbekistan's charge to regain the gold in the upcoming Olympiad at home in Samarkand

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SCIENCE

Urban Indian private schools at risk of proximity to toxic lead sites: report

A study has found that 90% of private schools in New Delhi are located near a site contaminated with lead, mercury, arsenic, and/or pesticides: as opposed to developed countries, the study found that in low- and middle-income countries, urban schools are 4- to 28-times more likely than rural schools to be near a toxic site

Monika Mondal
NEW DELHI

In high-income countries like the U.S. and the U.K., it is well-established that people who live in poorer and marginalised localities are more exposed to pollution than those in wealthier neighbourhoods. According to a recent report, that pattern seems to be reversed in low and middle income countries (LMIC) like India.

A report, titled 'Schools in the Shadow of Toxic Sites: Pollution Proximity in Low- and Middle-Income Countries', by the Center for Global Development (CGD) looked at how close 2,840 schools were to toxic sites in 17 countries. It concluded that 10% of schools in LMICs lie within 5 km of a documented toxic site, especially in urban areas.

And of all the world's capital cities, New Delhi topped the list, with more than 90% of its private schools located near a site contaminated with lead, mercury, cadmium, arsenic, and/or pesticides.

When exposed to such contaminants, children in particular develop higher risk of heart and kidney diseases as well as of irreversible learning and cognitive disabilities. According to the World Bank, lead exposure during childhood alone costs LMICs \$1 trillion a year.

'Equally exposed to contamination'

While lead exists naturally in the deep layers of the earth, no amount of lead exposure is safe for humans. Once it enters the body, it can stay silently stuck to the bones, mimicking calcium. When mixed with blood, it can lead to severe kidney and heart problems. In individuals showing no acute symptoms, it can spike blood pressure and lead to sudden heart attacks.

Among children, lead can be a powerful neurotoxin that degrades myelin, the protective outer layer of the brain, and hampers brain cell connections.

In the last few decades, more and more studies from both developed and developing countries have linked lead exposure to shortened attention spans, heightened aggression, behavioural disorders, and a permanent drop in IQ.

"But we did not know where exactly the problem was," Lee Crawford, the report's author and a researcher at the CGD, London.

For the analysis, Mr. Crawford mapped 2.6 million schools to 11,301 documented toxic sites across Mexico, India, Ghana, Kenya, Armenia, and 12 other countries. While the contamination was severe within a few metres of a site, pollutants do not remain there forever. People living as far as 5 km from a toxic site have shown to have elevated blood lead levels as well. "If you look at household lead



Stripping scrapped laptops and air conditioners for metal frequently involves burning away rubber wire casings, releasing lead, mercury, and cadmium into the air. When exposed to such contaminants, children develop higher risk of heart and kidney diseases as well as of cognitive disabilities. AFP

exposure, the poorest are slightly more likely to be exposed than the richest, but since lead exposure can be impactful within 5 km of radius, everyone who lives and breathes in the same air is equally exposed to the contamination," Mr. Crawford said.

The study found 9.7% of schools in the sample were within 5 km of a contaminated site. As a result, "Nearly a billion children have some lead exposure globally. And we know that a big share of that comes from polluted sites, many of them lead-battery recycling," Mr. Crawford said.

As opposed to developed countries, where polluting sites lie where public opposition is weakest, the study found that in LMICs, urban schools are 4- to 28-times more likely than rural schools to be near a toxic site. "The results are a bit surprising," Mr. Crawford said.

"But it makes sense with the urban clustering. If you don't have good regulation of where recycling can happen, then it happens in the most convenient places, which is where people are."

Paradox of development, recycling

Lead-acid batteries are used to start most petrol and diesel motor engines; lead is also present in smaller quantities in the electrical components of photovoltaic

cells, wind turbines, and as part of back-up power supply systems. These batteries alone contribute to 86% of global lead consumption.

Lead acid batteries are also popular because they are cheap, rechargeable, and easy to recycle. The metal melts at 327° C, a temperature that can be achieved using a blowtorch in a backyard. Thus, numerous informal enterprises have erupted in India that simply break open old batteries, isolate the lead-containing parts, and toss them in a furnace. The liquid lead is then filtered out and recast into ingots for new batteries.

But without a safe, closed-loop management system, the lead leaches into the soil and can enter human bodies through food, water, and the air.

In developed countries, lead is generally recycled under strict guidelines and with restrictions, and costs tens of millions of dollars. But in LMICs, where enforcement is weak and labour is cheap, a large proportion of recycling happens in backyards.

Thus, in India, even though there are more than 350 well-equipped recycling units, some 90% of the waste ends up in the informal network, where profits are also higher.

As per the report, this network is now

estimated to be responsible for around 33% of the world's lead poisoning burden. In LMICs, this burden is equivalent to 80 lakh disability-adjusted life years or 8 lakh annual deaths.

'An invisible problem'

Mr. Crawford said variables like a school being private, secondary or single-sex all correlated to some degree with higher pollution exposure simply because they were clustered in cities. New Delhi had 91.2% of schools within 5 km of a toxic site; it was followed by Manila (86%), Nairobi (71%), Accra (67%), and Jakarta (51%). This clustering is not inevitable, however: Mr. Crawford's analysis also found that Mexico City, despite its large size and high population density, had almost no toxic-site contamination because its industrial manufacturing zones were successfully regulated and separated from the urban core.

"Lead is an invisible problem that's easy to ignore," Mr. Crawford said. "But badly polluted sites can be regulated, closed down or moved out of city/populated areas. It's something that the Indian government has done and they can do it, with more public pressure."

(Monika Mondal is a freelance science and environment journalist. a.monikamondal@gmail.com)

THE GIST

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BIG SHOT



Smoke and fog in a burnt forest affected by a wildfire, near Saumos, Gironde, on Tuesday, amid drought conditions following a heatwave across much of France. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

Andromeda: galactic middle age

Vasudevan Mukunth

Astronomers have used data collected by the Hubble Space Telescope to piece together the clearest yet map of star formation across most of the Andromeda Galaxy over the last 500 million years. The Andromeda is 2.2-2.5-times wider than the Milky Way, and the two galaxies have a coin-toss's chance of colliding within the next 10 billion years.

Using their map, the astronomers found that the Andromeda's star formation rate has been steadily dropping, especially over the last 40 million years. Recent star formation was concentrated in the Galaxy's ring structures, and that is where the rate is declining most as well.

They also found a 'dead zone' near M32, a small satellite galaxy of the Andromeda. Specifically, in the part of Andromeda closest to M32, they found new stars had almost completely stopped forming — an indication that M32 had likely crashed through or interacted with Andromeda's disc of stars (stellar disc) recently, disrupting the gas clouds from which new stars are born.

The team interpreted their data to mean the Andromeda Galaxy is currently transitioning to its 'middle age', away from being a vibrant, active galaxy and towards a quiescent state akin to retirement. The researchers also said that astronomers need better ways to



A true-colour photo of the Andromeda Galaxy. M32 is visible above. DAVID DAYAG (CC BY-SA)

measure distant galaxies: if a galaxy's activity is changing fast, their usual tools could be revealing a false picture of its health. Thus, they concluded, understanding Andromeda can point the way to better understanding the lives of massive galaxies.

The findings were published in *The Astrophysical Journal* on July 27.

For feedback and suggestions for 'Science', please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Daily page'